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Improve Your Communication Skills

How to build trust, be heard and
communicate with confidence

Alan Barker



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ABOUT THIS BOOK

We all need to communicate better at work. A survey by the Economist Intelligence Unit (EIU), conducted in 2017 in the US, found that miscommunication is delaying projects and contributing to lost sales, as well as increasing stress and destroying morale.

And the problem is affecting our organizations at every level.

If you're a senior manager, you might see the problem as one of leadership. Two-thirds of business leaders surveyed by the Interact consultancy in 2016 said that 'there is something about their role as a leader that makes them uncomfortable communicating with their employees'.

You may be one of those employees. You might be a millennial, born between 1981 and 1999: one of a generation who generally use social media at work far more than their (mainly) older managers. According to Art Markman, Professor of Psychology and Marketing at the University of Texas at Austin, millennials wishing to become leaders will need to master the skills of communicating in person: 'We have a generation,' he explains in the EIU report, 'who is not as practised at engaging in real time with people.'

If you're a middle manager, you face a particular challenge. You spend a lot of time shuttling information and ideas between senior and junior execs. As Mr Markman explains, 'Communication is one of the most significant parts of [a middle manager's] job because they're dealing with the widest variety of people.'

And if you're entering the world of work, it's worth knowing that communication skills head the list of must-haves in new recruits. In the Graduate Management Admission Council's (GMAC's) 2017 Corporate Recruiters Survey, the two top-rated skills that employers look for when hiring are speaking and listening. Third in line is adaptability, the ability to flex communication style. Written skills and presentation skills take the next two places.

Interestingly, employers rated managerial skills consistently as least important.

The GMAC's survey reflects the fact that every organization is a network of conversations. Our success depends on the way we speak and listen to each other. Most of us know that: 65 per cent of those surveyed in the EIU report rated face-to-face meetings as very effective, but only 22 per cent claimed to have such meetings every day. Globalization, outsourcing and flexible working are making it harder to talk face-to-face. Ever more rigorous auditing forces co-workers sitting at the same desk to exchange emails. We look at screens, some of us, more than we look at each other.

It starts with us. If we can speak and listen more effectively, then our videoconferences, presentations and reports will all improve. More than that, we'll be able to adapt our own communication styles to the increasingly varied styles our colleagues bring to work.

That's why, in this new edition, I've added a questionnaire to help you identify your own preferred style and become a more adaptable communicator. And it's why I've maintained a core focus on the four top-rated skills of corporate communication. Speaking, listening, presenting and writing: master those skills and you'll be well placed to win the job you want, manage more efficiently and lead more effectively.

01

What is communication?

Communicate: it's what we humans do. We're not alone, of course: every living thing sends messages in one way or another, to help it navigate its environment or attract others. Movements, sounds, scents – even the shape and colour of a flower communicates useful information to the insects or birds that are drawn to it.

But we humans seem to have developed certain kinds of communication to a rare pitch of sophistication. Our command of spoken language is extraordinary; but just as impressive are our abilities to read facial expressions, tone of voice and gestures.

In fact, communicating comes so naturally to most of us that it's sometimes hard to see why it goes wrong – especially at work. Why should a skill that comes to most of us so effortlessly become such a tortuous process in an organization?

Let's begin by thinking about what we mean by the word 'communication'.

Exercise

Complete this sentence in no more than 12 words.

Communication is...

Ask a few colleagues for their ideas. Compare your thoughts.

Are you defining communication in all its forms? Are you defining effective communication? What makes communication ineffective? Can you agree on a definition?

The transmission model

In the 19th century, the word ‘communication’ referred mainly to the movement of goods and people. We still use the word like this, of course: roads and railways are forms of communication, just as much as speaking or writing.

And we still use industrial images as metaphors for communication. Information, like freight, needs to be stored, transferred and retrieved. And we often describe the movement of information in terms of a ‘channel’, along which information ‘flows’.

In the 20th century, this transport metaphor readily adapted itself to new, electronic technologies: we have ‘telephone lines’ and ‘television channels’. Electronic information comes in ‘bits’, stored in ‘files’ or ‘vaults’. The words ‘download’ and ‘upload’ use the freight metaphor; email uses postal imagery.

So it wouldn’t be surprising, in that exercise just now, if you defined communication as ‘the effective transfer of information’. We ‘have’ an idea (as if the idea were an object). We ‘put the idea into words’ (like putting it into a box); we try to ‘put our idea across’ (by ‘conveying’ it); and the ‘receiver’ – hopefully – ‘gets’ the idea. We may need to ‘unpack’ the idea before the receiver can fully ‘grasp’ it. Of course, we need to be careful to avoid ‘information overload’.

This is the transmission model of communication. And it’s very powerful. It governs all the processes and policies by which we communicate in organizations. It suggests that information is objective and measurable (how many bits are we transmitting?). Above all, the model’s simple: we can draw a diagram to illustrate it.

Turning the transmission model around

So what’s wrong with the transmission model? Well, to begin with, it doesn’t seem to reflect the way people actually communicate.

Wii's laws of communication

Osmo Wii, a Finnish professor, developed these laws of corporate communication. They describe with frightening accuracy the failings of the transmission model, especially in organizations.

- Communication usually fails, except by accident.
- If communication can fail, it will fail.
- If communication cannot fail, it still usually fails.
- If communication seems to succeed in the way you intend – someone's misunderstood.
- If you are content with your message, communication is certainly failing.
- If a message can be interpreted in several ways, it will be interpreted in a manner that maximizes the damage.
- There is always someone who knows better than you what your message means.
- The more we communicate, the more communication fails.

Perhaps the transmission metaphor is inaccurate. After all, a message isn't really like a parcel. When I send the parcel, it's no longer with me; in contrast, when I send a message, I still have it.

But there's a more serious reason why the transmission model fails to describe communication accurately.

The model's the wrong way around.

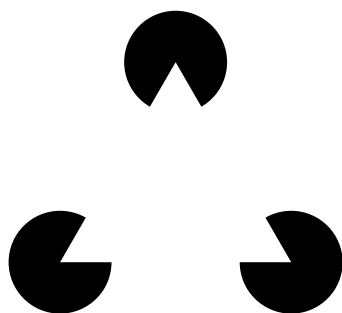
Here's the first and most important point: communication begins, not with transmission, but with understanding. No matter how effectively I transmit a message, it won't communicate to you if you don't understand it. If we want to improve our communication skills, we could start by focusing, not on how we transmit information and ideas, but on how we *understand* them.

Pattern-matching: The secret of understanding

So how *do* we understand? The simple answer is: by pattern-matching. Mental models in our brains filter the information we pick up through our five senses and create meaning.

Here's a very simple example. Take a look at Figure 1.1.

Figure 1.1 A Kanizsa triangle



What can you see? Probably a white triangle. Of course, there *is* no white triangle; your brain has matched the available information to its store of mental models, and come up with the best guess of a white triangle. (The triangle's named after Gaetano Kanizsa, an Italian psychologist and artist, founder of the Institute of Psychology of Trieste.)

Scientists call this process of filling in the gaps 'perceptual completion', and it's not limited to visual information. How can I distinguish your voice from all the other noise in a crowded room? How can a taste bring back a childhood memory, or a scent remind us of someone we love? Our brains match information to a mental model and *complete* the pattern. As Stephen Jay Gould famously said: 'The mind, basically, is a pattern-seeking machine.'

Our mental models make sense of the world for us. Indeed, they create the world for us. As Joe Griffin and Ivan Tyrrell explain in their book *Human Givens*, 'without mental models, no world would exist for us. They organize our reality'.

Getting to know each other

Pattern-matching isn't restricted to triangles, tunes and perfumes. Every time we encounter another person, they're pattern-matching, seeking to understand us by using the mental models that they've developed. Those models are considerably more complicated and various than a white triangle; but the *process* of pattern-matching is just the same. And of course, that process is happening, even if we're not trying to communicate. All that's necessary is that someone is observing us.

We can't *not* communicate. Or, to paraphrase Marshall McLuhan: the effect we have on others is what we communicate.

Top tip

Whenever you start a conversation, try to ask yourself: 'What effect am I having here?' And then ask: 'What effect do I *want* to have?'

Pattern-matching between people, of course, is never one-way. Just as the other person is seeking to understand us, so we pattern-match to try to understand them. Each of us is noticing each other's words, expressions and behaviour, and making a best guess about the information we're receiving. If we want to continue the process, we'll try to match our patterns *to each other*.

And so begins a subtle dance between us: the gentle exchange of attention and action that we call conversation. We start to mirror each other's stance and each other's gestures; our voices begin to chime together, matching rhythm, pace and pitch. We may even begin to anticipate each other's words and finish each other's sentences.

Building rapport

We usually refer to this process of establishing mutual understanding as ‘building rapport’. And the images we use to describe it aren’t the images of railways or couriers. We don’t talk about transmitting information. Instead, we might use the language of music. You may feel that I’m ‘on your wavelength’; I may feel that we’re ‘in tune’. Perhaps we feel ‘a sense of harmony’, or that ‘we’re singing from the same song sheet’. Rapport is one of the great pleasures of human communication, and when it doesn’t happen, we can feel uncomfortable or disappointed.

Most rapport occurs spontaneously. But we can build it deliberately. When we do so, rapport becomes more than an enjoyable activity; it becomes a communication skill.

To develop our rapport-building skills, we need to think about our:

- visual behaviour;
- vocal behaviour; and
- verbal behaviour.

Overwhelmingly, we believe what we see. If there’s a mismatch between what I say and what my body’s doing, you’re going to believe my body. So building rapport deliberately must begin with giving the visual signs of being welcoming, relaxed and open. And visual rapport extends to the way we look: our stance, the way we relate to the other person in space, even our clothes.

The music of the voice builds vocal rapport. We can vary our pitch (how high or low the tone of voice is), pace (the speed of speaking) and volume (how loudly or softly we speak). If any of these three elements jars with the other person, they’ll feel uncomfortable.

Top tip

Think about developing your vocal skills. Consider joining Toastmasters to practise your public speaking. Joining a choir can work wonders for your voice – and your social skills.

We build verbal rapport through the words we speak. If the other person feels that we are speaking their language, they'll feel more comfortable with us and more willing to continue the conversation. Listen to the words the other person uses and try to use them yourself.

Most of us know what it's like to feel 'lost for words'. How can we start a conversation with someone we don't know well, at a networking event, in a meeting, or in a performance review?

The key is to ask a question. Look for something in your shared situation to talk about, and ask a question relating to that. Avoid talking about yourself, and avoid asking a direct question that the other person might find intrusive. Take the initiative. Put the other person at ease, and you'll soon relax yourself.

Exercise

Here's a simple method to establish rapport with someone you don't know. Try it out in the staff restaurant, at social gatherings, in networking meetings and at conferences.

- 1 Copy the other person's body language to create a 'mirror image'.
- 2 Ask three questions – but no more than three until you've done the next two things.
- 3 Find something from what you've just learned that will allow you to compliment the other person – subtly.

- 4 Find something in what you have found out to agree with.
- 5 Repeat steps 1 to 4 until the conversation takes on a life of its own.

(With thanks to Chris Dyas.)

Communication: A new definition

We need, then, to redefine the word ‘communication’. The transmission model is quite inadequate to describe this complex process – pattern-matching, rapport-building, the nuances of conversation – adequately.

The clue to a possible new definition lies in the history of the word. ‘Communication’ derives from the Latin *communis*, meaning ‘shared’. It belongs to the family of words that includes *communion*, *communism* and *community*.

Top tip

Communication is the process of creating shared understanding.

We seek to create shared understanding in all sorts of ways. We speak on the phone and hold videoconferences; we spend hours producing slides for corporate presentations; we write emails and texts, web pages and blog posts. Humans now enjoy an astonishingly wide range of communication technologies.

Conversation: The currency of communication

And yet, the basic unit of human communication remains what it has always been: conversation.

We hold conversations to build relationships and to make sense of reality. We influence each other's thoughts, feelings and actions by holding conversations. We converse to solve problems, to cooperate and find new things to do. Conversation is our way of imagining and creating the future.

Every conversation is a dynamic process of listening and speaking. It uses language: words, of course, but also those other kinds of language that we've just mentioned: visual language like gestures and eye contact; and vocal language, expressed in the music of our voices.

We can think of a conversation as being like a verbal dance. The word 'conversation' comes from Latin words meaning 'to move around with'. Different kinds of conversation, like different kinds of dance, have different rules.

Exercise

Think about the words we use to describe different kinds of conversation. Write down a few of them. How do they differ? Can you identify any of the rules that apply to each?

For example, you might think of the word 'chat', and the word 'discussion'. What's the difference between the two? Do chats and discussions follow different rules?

Can you think of any other words describing different kinds of conversation?

As our conversations grow and develop, the skills of listening and speaking become the broader, deeper skills of enquiry and persuasion. In Chapters 4 and 5, we'll explore those two complementary sets of skills. We all balance these skills in different ways. Those differences contribute to our different communication styles – and it's those styles we'll explore in the next chapter.

Summary points

- Communication begins, not with transmission, but with understanding.
- Understanding is a pattern-matching process.
- Sometimes, we have to fill in the gaps to make the pattern.
- By asking: 'What effect am I having?' in any conversation, we can begin to build rapport.
- We can build rapport deliberately, by managing our:
 - physical behaviour;
 - vocal behaviour; and
 - verbal behaviour.
- Communication is the process of creating shared understanding.
- Conversation is the principal tool we use.

02

What's your communication style?

We all communicate in different ways. And that can cause problems. In the 2017 survey conducted by the Economist Intelligence Unit, the most frequently cited cause of poor communication at work was a clash of different communication styles. In the words of the survey's authors, 'managers need to tailor their communication styles to those around them to be effective'.

In this chapter, we'll look at different styles of communicating. We'll discover the style or styles that we prefer; we'll learn how to assess other people's preferences; and, most importantly, we'll discover how to adapt our own style to different situations.

Communication style questionnaire

Take a look at this list of phrases. Decide which of them best describe the way you communicate, and put a ring around the letter beside it. You can mark as many or as few phrases as you wish.

Likes to be in control	f
Prefers a lot of detail on which to base decisions	a
Expresses ideas spontaneously, sometimes without thinking	e
Finds it difficult to say 'no' when asked to do something	s
Neat and organized	a

Looks for firm decisions and clear actions	f
Prefers to be a team player	s
Likes to talk about the 'big picture'	e
Seeks overt approval and praise	e
Dislikes inaction	f
Good at counselling others	s
Likes to base ideas on numbers and statistics	a
Prefers maximum freedom to manage themselves and others	f
Knows where to find the data needed to solve a problem	a
Good at gaining support from others	s
Knows and applies the rules	f
Does things one step at a time	a
Can become impatient with others' feelings, attitudes and advice	f
Searches for a workable compromise	s
Encourages and energizes others	e
Decides and acts cautiously	a
Good at making presentations and speeches	e
Technically proficient	f
Needs others' support to set goals	s
Gets bored with too much talking and too little doing	f
Prepares and studies things in advance	a
Breaks processes into steps and explains each step	f
Uses statistics and evidence to prove arguments	a
Likes to inspire others	e
Wants to keep the peace	s
Good at finding practical solutions to problems	f
Good ice-breaker and socializer	s
Dreams and inspires others to dream	e
Breaks information into parts to understand it	a

Likes making decisions	f
Enjoys variety and change	e
Sensitive to others' feelings	s
Looks for the right way to do something	f
Prefers to work alone on problems	a
Seeks security and a sense of belonging	s
Likes to be asked by others to find the answer	f
Never trusts opinions unsupported by facts	a
Tends to thrive on adrenaline	e
Reads people well	s
Does not like to waste time	f
Thinks best by discussing ideas with other people	e
Needs a conceptual framework to solve problems	a
Dislikes conflict	s

Now count up all the instances of each letter you have ringed. The total is your score for that letter. For example, if you have ringed the letter 'f' six times, your score for 'f' is 6.

Record your score for each letter here:

s:

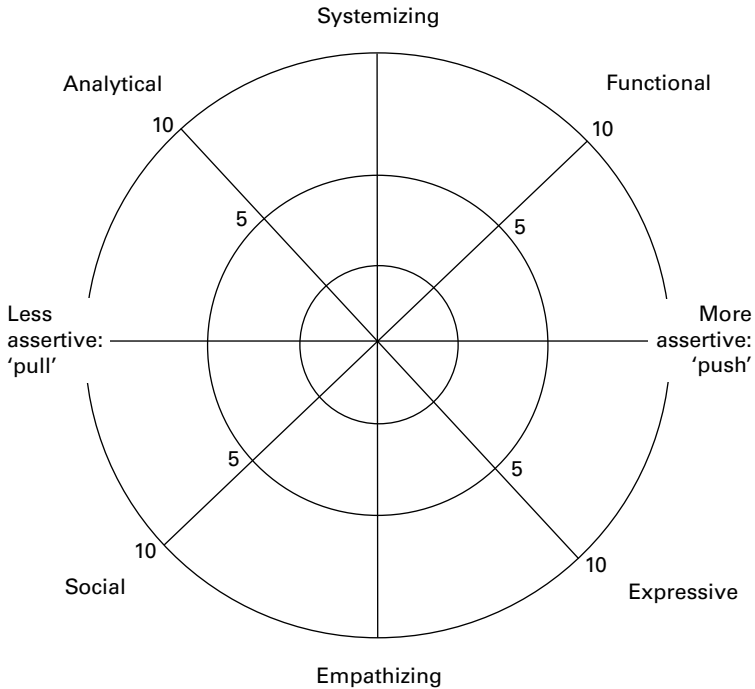
a:

f:

e:

Now transfer your scores onto Figure 2.1. Mark each score on the appropriate diagonal line: 's' stands for 'Social', 'a' for 'Analytical', 'f' for 'Functional', and 'e' for 'Expressive'. Lower scores sit towards the centre of the diagram, and higher scores toward the edge.

Join each of the four points you have marked with straight lines, to create a four-sided shape. Mark that shape strongly so that you can see your communication style profile clearly.

Figure 2.1 Communication styles map

Understanding your communication profile

This communication profile is based on two sets of complementary behaviours. Together, they create a useful picture of the ways we prefer to communicate with others.

Push and pull: Managing status

The first pair of complementary behaviours express our relationship in a conversation.

We can model this relationship using the idea of status. Status is our position relative to each other – and it's brutally simple: by definition, our status can only be higher or lower than that of the person we're communicating with. Think of status as being like a see-saw: if we raise our status, the other person's status automatically goes down. If we raise their status, our end of the see-saw automatically dips. We can think of rapport – which we looked at in the previous chapter – as *levelling* status.

The shorthand for raising our own status is 'pushing'. The core 'push' behaviour is to speak. Examples of 'pushing', in increasing order of intensity, might include making a statement, persuading, bargaining, criticizing, instructing, invoking rules, demanding, or using force.

Conversely, the shorthand for raising the other person's status is 'pulling', and the core 'pull' behaviour is to listen. Other examples, in increasing order of intensity, might include asking a question, exploring an idea, encouraging, praising, giving way, or obeying.

The behaviours of 'pushing' and 'pulling' are on a spectrum. Most conversations will include a mix of both, because most conversations include a mix of speaking and listening. Most of us can do both, and we can develop our skills in both. But most of us will tend to prefer one set of these behaviours over the other: put simply, we tend to prefer either speaking or listening.

Empathizing and systemizing

The second pair of complementary behaviours express how we prefer to understand the world around us.

We saw in the previous chapter that understanding is principally about pattern-matching. We seek to match our experiences with mental models that we have built up in our minds. People with very different mental models will have to work harder to understand each other. What the Economist Intelligence Unit report calls 'a clash of communication styles' is also a clash of mental models.

Empathizing and systemizing are two modes of pattern-matching, and they look at the world in two different ways.

Empathizing is the drive to identify another person's emotions and thoughts, and to respond to them with appropriate behaviour. It arises out of a natural desire to care for others, and an awareness of how others see us. We empathize when we sense that someone's emotions have shifted, and we wonder why. Empathy helps us tune in to another person's world, and pattern-match to their mental models. It stops us offending, insulting or injuring them. Empathizing starts from the understanding that ours may not be the only way to look at the world, and that others' mental models – their thoughts, feelings and values – matter as much as ours.

Top tip

Think about someone with whom you find it hard to empathize. Can you pick out specific ways in which you each see the world differently? If you can identify a particular mental model that this person seems to hold, can you imagine holding that same mental model? How would your view of the world change?

Systemizing is the drive to understand our environment by constructing systems. A system is any set of elements that operates on inputs and delivers outputs, according to 'if-then' rules. If it rains, the pond in the garden fills with water. If I flick the switch, then the light will come on. If I add two to three using the rules of decimal addition, I get five. If sea water rises to a certain temperature, coral reefs will die.

Systemizing seeks to understand how things work, and in particular the *rules* that govern how they work. The great advantage of systemizing is that it allows us to predict how a system will behave. Systemizing gives us control over our environment.

Systems come in all shapes and sizes. According to Simon Baron-Cohen, we can recognize (at least) six types of system: technical (machines of any kind), natural (an organism, a pond, a forest), abstract (languages, computer codes), social (teams, companies, families), organizable (encyclopedias, libraries), and motoric (playing a musical instrument, swimming).

Just as 'pushing' and 'pulling' are on a spectrum, so empathizing and systemizing are complementary processes. We can all – most of us – both empathize and systemize. But we tend to prefer one or the other, and that preference will affect our communication style.

Four communication styles

We can combine these two spectra of behaviour – 'push'/'pull', empathize/systemize – to create four broad styles of communication: Social, Analytical, Functional and Expressive. (The acronym SAFE will help you remember them.) Most of us prefer one or two of these styles over the others. Identifying your own preferred styles will help you extend your skills into other styles – and become a more competent communicator.

A word of caution here. We're talking here about *style*; we're not discussing what kind of person you are. Just as we prefer to dress in certain ways, so we prefer to communicate using certain styles. And, just as we can choose to dress differently, so we can all choose to communicate differently. Most of us can alter our communication style quite easily in certain situations. For example, we'd behave quite differently at a funeral and at a birthday party – just as we'd probably dress differently. Changing our behaviour in this way is what the Economist Intelligence Unit report calls 'tailoring' our communication style. You may not be able to change your personality; but you can choose to behave differently.

Social: Connecting to others (‘pull’; empathizing)

The Social style seeks to understand other people, so that we can improve our relationships with them. We use the Social style to discover what people are thinking and feeling. This style foregrounds listening over speaking, and asking questions over making statements. When we make statements in this style, we use language that expresses emotions openly and connects to other people.

The Social style is the style of the diplomat. When you display this style, people will turn to you as the team player, the consensus-builder, the peacemaker. Indeed, this style is conflict-averse and may not be able to deal with personal criticism easily. And criticism might come from people working in other styles: the Analytical style, for instance, may become irritated with Social’s ‘touchy-feely’ approach. Under pressure, the Social style might become upset and exasperated.

Analytical: Doing the research (‘pull’; systemizing)

The Analytical style seeks to understand the environment better. We use this style to understand how things work in the world. This style likes data, numbers and systems for organizing them. It might become irritated with people who can’t support their opinions with hard evidence. Like the Social style, Analytical foregrounds listening – or observing – over speaking. Analytical will pick up the trends and underlying causes of events that others might miss. When Analytical speaks, it uses specific, unemotional language – especially the language of measurement or definition.

Analytical is the style of the researcher. People turn to Analytical for clear, dispassionate, logical answers to hard questions. Like Social, Analytical tends to avoid conflict and may therefore find it hard to make a tough decision. Others might call this ‘analysis

paralysis'. When confronted with such criticism, Analytical may become terse and even rude.

Functional: Making it work (‘push’; systemizing)

The Functional style seeks to get things done in the world. We use this style to achieve practical results. Functional foregrounds speaking over listening. It generates and explains processes: timelines, plans, and deliverables.

Functional is the style of the implementer. People turn to this style to make things happen, on time and on budget. The Functional style covers all the details. It may become irritated with the Social style because it's more interested in processes than people. It may ally itself with the Analytical style but become impatient with its hesitation to act. Because it focuses on process and not people, other styles may find Functional cold, unresponsive or – worst of all – boring. The Functional style can therefore lose people's attention in presentations or meetings.

Expressive: Putting on a show (‘push’; empathizing)

The Expressive style seeks to make an impression on other people. We use the Expressive style to present, perform and inspire. This style creates the big picture, using images and stories. Expressive foregrounds speaking over listening; it thinks imaginatively and laterally.

When we use the Expressive style, we're seeking to engage our audience; indeed, we'll tend to see other people principally as an audience rather than a partner in a conversation. An Expressive speaker is acutely aware of how its audience is thinking and feeling – especially about the speaker themselves. The ultimate aim of the Expressive style is to change hearts and minds.

The Expressive style is the style of the visionary. It prefers big ideas to irritating details. It finds its natural home on the podium – or in the pulpit. We call on the Expressive style to tell corporate stories and challenge the status quo. The Expressive style may find the Analytical style irritating and the Functional style pedestrian. Indeed, the Expressive style may lack the necessary patience to make an informed decision. It may ally itself with the Social style but hijack it for its own ends.

If you've completed this exercise, you'll have a good idea of the way you prefer to communicate. You may come out very strong on just one style; you may find that you combine two as preferred styles. Some people score relatively equally in all four styles; if that's you, then you can congratulate yourself on being a highly adaptable communicator!

Understanding others' styles

Once you've got to know this communication styles model, you can also use it to understand how other people like to communicate.

- People who focus on you and ask you lots of questions are using the Social style.
- People who focus on the task and ask lots of questions about it are using the Analytical style.
- People who make a lot of statements about a task or process are using the Functional style.
- People who use statements to inspire or entertain you are using the Expressive style.

Understanding the style that someone is using will give you clues about how to adapt your own style, so that you can communicate more effectively.

Table 2.1 Understanding others' preferred styles

	Analytical	Functional	Social	Expressive
Fall-back:	Avoids	Resorts to rules	Gives in	Attacks
They value:	Activity and precision	Results and the bottom-line	Attention and friendship	Recognition
They may need to learn how to:	Make decisions	Listen	Initiate action	Check the detail
Manage them best by:	Providing detail	Allowing them to build own structure	Making suggestions and facilitating	Inspiring them to reach their goals
They like to be:	Accurate	Efficient	Agreeable	Stimulating/visionary
Support them with:	Principles and thinking	Conclusion and action	Relationships and feelings	Applause and praise
To help decisions, provide:	Evidence and service	Options and probabilities	Guarantees and assurances	Testimony and incentives

Body language: Non-verbal communication

Conversations, of course, are never simply exchanges of words. We also speak to each other with our bodies – or rather, our bodies often speak for us. Hence the name for this complicated set of behaviours: body language. Some of this language is vocal: the rhythm, tone and volume of our voice, all the grunts, sighs and laughter that surround our words. And some body language is visual: the way we move our eyes or hold someone's gaze, the gestures we use, our posture, the way we move towards or away

from another person. All of these elements contribute to our communication style.

What's your preferred body language?

Think about the communication style or styles that you prefer. How does body language contribute to that style? Think about how you use your voice: pace, tonal variation, volume. Think also about how you use your body to express your ideas. Above all, think about what you do with your eyes when you are holding a conversation.

How could you alter your body language to make it more effective?

Body language is largely unconscious. Actors (and con artists) can consciously control their non-verbal behaviour, but it takes a lot of training. Most of us find it hard to manage body language, especially if we're stressed. 'Under pressure,' writes Tracy Cox, 'our bodies leak. Our true feelings come gushing out in gestures.'

Body language can be surprisingly hard to interpret. There are four main reasons for this.

- 1 Body language is ambiguous.** No dictionary can accurately define non-verbal signals. Their meaning can vary according to context. Some people close their eyes to concentrate on what you're saying; others do so to try to avoid paying you attention.
- 2 Body language is continuous.** We can stop talking but we can't stop our bodies behaving!
- 3 Body language is multichannel.** Everything happens at once: eyes, hands, feet, body position. We interpret non-verbal messages holistically, as a complete impression. This makes them strong but unspecific: we may not be able to pin down what the behaviour is suggesting to us.

4 Body language, like any other language, is culturally determined.

Research suggests that a few non-verbal messages are universal: everybody seems to smile when they're happy, for example. Most non-verbal behaviours, however, are specific to a culture. A lot of confusion can arise from the misinterpretation of non-verbal messages across a cultural divide.

Our body language, then, can sometimes say things that we don't intend. (Remember that key question in Chapter 1? *What effect am I having?*) We may not know what our bodies are saying; and the other person may be misinterpreting our non-verbal messages.

If you want to work on your non-verbal communication, start with your eyes. If you think more about where you're looking during a conversation, you can find ways to give your words added weight. At its simplest, by looking steadily at the other person and keeping fairly still, you'll probably immediately make the conversation more comfortable.

Key questions: Managing behaviour

- **Look for clusters**

If you're picking up a group of non-verbal messages that seem to indicate a single feeling, you may be able to trust your interpretation more fully.

- **Consider past experience**

We can interpret more accurately the behaviour of people we know. We certainly notice changes in their behaviour. We also interpret patterns of behaviour over time more accurately than single instances.

- **Check your perceptions**

Ask questions. You're interpreting observed behaviour, not reading someone's mind. Check out what you observe and make sure that your interpretation is accurate.

- **Work on your eyes and your gestures**

Think about where you're looking during the conversation and how you're moving.

Adapting our communication style

We've taken two steps towards making our own communication style more flexible. We have some understanding of our own preferred style, and we're now better able to assess other people's preferred styles. The final step is to find ways of adapting our style to different people and situations.

Effective communicators manage their behaviour. They work hard to align their non-verbal messages with their words. You may feel that altering your behaviour is dishonest or inauthentic: 'play-acting' a part that you don't feel. But – and we return to this hard lesson – the important question is not what we feel, but what *effect* we're having. Managing our behaviour simply means trying to act appropriately: trying to have the right effect on the other person.

Exercise

Here's a thought experiment. Identify the style in the questionnaire on which you scored *lowest*. Now identify situations in which you would benefit from using that style. What would you need to do to develop your skills in that area? What's the first thing you could do?

Adaptability is our willingness and ability to change our behaviour. We've looked at four styles: Social, Analytical, Functional and Expressive. No one style is naturally more adaptable than another. And we're all able to adapt our styles to some extent. We can usu-

ally adapt our style more easily with strangers than with people we know well. For example, imagine being promoted from being a member of a team to leading the team: the communication style that worked with our co-workers will probably need to change when we start to manage them.

We can test our ability to adapt our behaviour in situations where we don't *want* to adapt, but *choose* to adapt. Here are some ideas to help you get started.

- If you prefer systemizing styles – Analytical or Functional – you could think about ways of displaying more empathic behaviour. Take a moment to explain how you feel about a situation; spend more time on the relationship by asking the other person how they feel. Put yourself into situations where you can encourage, praise or flatter people.
- If you prefer empathizing styles – Social or Expressive – you might look for opportunities to do more systematic thinking. You might need to restrain your social chat or control your enthusiasm. Focus on the task at hand. Make sure you understand the elements contributing to a problem, and the steps needed to resolve it.
- If you prefer 'pulling' styles – Analytical or Social – then you could look for opportunities to assert your point of view a little more. Make sure that you make your points simply and clearly; maybe even seek to be a little controversial. Focus on action.
- And if you prefer 'pushing' styles – Functional or Expressive – you could practise listening before speaking, asking for others' views, letting others take control of a conversation and seeking consensus rather than imposing your own views.

Don't try to adapt your style all the time. And think about *how much* you want to adapt your style. The temporary stress of behaving in a foreign style might be worth suffering, for the sake of increasing rapport with others. Extreme adaptability, on the other hand, could make you appear inconsistent or dishonest.

Being able to adapt your communication style will bring you multiple benefits at work. Adaptable people interact more productively with everyone they work with. They can manage difficult or tense situations more effectively. They make life easier for everyone.

The uses of conversation

All of the communication styles that we've explored in this chapter reveal themselves in conversation. And all the other modes of communication that we explore in this book are related, in some way, to conversation. In Chapter 4, we look at the skills of enquiry, which build on our powers of listening. And Chapter 5 looks at the complementary skills of persuasion: how we influence each other's thoughts and feelings by speaking. Chapter 6 explores tough conversations: the conversations we might want to avoid, or that suddenly erupt when we least expect them.

Chapters 7 and 8 discuss what we might call 'conversation at a distance'. A presentation, for example, is a conversation in which one person will (probably) speak more than anyone else. And writing is a kind of conversation which lacks most aspects of non-verbal communication. And yet the new technologies – email, texting, instant messaging, Twitter – are part of a wider trend bringing writing closer to the spoken word – a trend that brings new challenges and the need for new skills.

Finally, in Chapter 9, we look at networking. Increasingly, we need to be able to communicate with strangers, quickly, comfortably and productively. Networking is a new kind of conversation, and it holds the key to success in many areas of our lives.

But first, let's look a little more at conversation: this most powerful and fascinating of communication skills. How can we improve the conversations we hold, at home, at work and in social situations? Chapter 3 provides some suggestions.

Summary points

- We all need to be able to tailor our communication style to different situations and people.
- We can profile our own preferred communication style using two sets of complementary behaviours:
 - pushing and pulling; and
 - empathizing and systemizing.
- Combining these sets of behaviours creates four communication styles:
 - Social;
 - Analytical;
 - Functional; and
 - Expressive.
- Most of us display a preference for one or two of these styles.
- The model also allows us to assess other people's preferred communication styles.
- Our communication style is also displayed by our non-verbal communication or body language: visual gestures and movements; and the tone, volume and speed of our voice.
- Body language can be surprisingly hard to interpret, and we need to check our perceptions of it.
- Effective communicators manage their behaviour.
- Adaptability is our willingness and ability to change our behaviour.
- We can test our ability to adapt our behaviour in situations where we don't *want* to adapt, but *choose* to adapt.
- Don't try to adapt your style all the time.
- Being able to adapt your communication style will bring you multiple benefits at work.
- All of the communication styles that we've explored in this chapter reveal themselves in conversation.

03

Seven ways to improve your conversations

We hold all sorts of conversations at work. Some are relaxed chats (often called ‘water-cooler talk’); others are planned. How can we make them more productive?

In this chapter, we look at seven proven strategies.

- Clarify your objective.
- Structure your thinking.
- Manage your time.
- Find common ground.
- Move beyond argument.
- Summarize often.
- Use visuals.

Don’t feel that you must apply all seven at once. Take a single strategy and work at it for a few days. (You should have plenty of conversations to practise on!) Once you feel that you have integrated one skill into your conversations, move on to another.

Clarify your objective

Think of a conversation as a journey you are taking with another person. It will very quickly start to wander off track if you don't know where you're going. You'll reach your destination only if you know where you're aiming for.

State your objective clearly at the start. Think of it as 'headlining'. Use headlines to give the reader the key message of a story, and we can do something similar in our conversations:

I want to talk to you about the development plan.

I know you're worried about the sales figures. I've got some clues that might help.

I've called this meeting to make a decision about project X.

Objectives roughly divide into two categories: 1) exploring a problem; 2) finding a solution. When you're thinking about your headline, ask: 'problem or solution?' We often assume that any conversation about a problem is aiming to find a solution. As a result, we may find ourselves working towards a solution without accurately defining or understanding the problem. (More on this in the next section, 'Structure your thinking'.)

In a meeting, the best place to announce the objectives of the conversation is on the agenda. That word means 'things to be done'. Use your agenda to list what you want to do in the meeting, not just what you want to talk about. For example, rather than a bald heading such as 'IT infrastructure', write something like 'Review supplier options for IT support and choose preferred bidder'. You have stated the conversation's objective; now everyone in the meeting knows where the conversation should be going.

Of course, you might decide to change your objective in the middle of the conversation – just as you might decide to change direction in the middle of a journey. That's fine, as long as everyone in the conversation knows what's going on. Indeed, if you make your objective too specific at the start of the conversation, you

might limit your options for success at the end. In a negotiation, for example, think about different possible destinations: what is your preferred outcome, what would you be willing to settle for, and what's non-negotiable?

Structure your thinking

You can improve your conversations enormously by giving them structure. The simplest way to structure a conversation is to break it into two halves.

We can imagine thinking as a process in two stages. We do *first-stage thinking* when we're working out what we're thinking about; we do *second-stage thinking* when we're working out what to do about it. First-stage thinking explores reality and translates what we've found into language; second-stage thinking then manipulates the language to decide what to do. We could say that first-stage thinking is perception, and second-stage thinking is judgement.

We often ignore first-stage thinking. We may assume that we know what we're looking at. But, of course, the quality of our second-stage thinking depends directly on the quality of our first-stage thinking. If our perception of a situation is limited, then our judgement about it will be limited. If we misunderstand a problem, then we may come up with a poor solution.

I sometimes think that we can be obsessed with solutions. Under pressure of time and the drive for results, we often leap to second-stage thinking without spending nearly enough time in the first stage. We don't explore the problems we're trying to solve. Indeed, we may not want to look too long at a problem; better, we might think, to deal with it and push it out of the way. (Or, maybe, simply ignore it and hope that it will disappear.) Problems – especially unresolved problems – can be disturbing.

However troubling the problem may be, try to explore it as fully as possible. Give first-stage thinking as much time and attention as you can.

Then give it a little more. And make sure that all participants in the conversation are at the same stage of thinking at the same time.

Top tip

In meetings, invite and encourage different views of the problem from different participants – especially from group members who may not be speaking very much. You may be straying into delicate or controversial areas, but the wider the range of views you have, the more richly you'll understand the problem.

The trick is to find the link between the two stages of thinking. Skilled conversationalists work on linking:

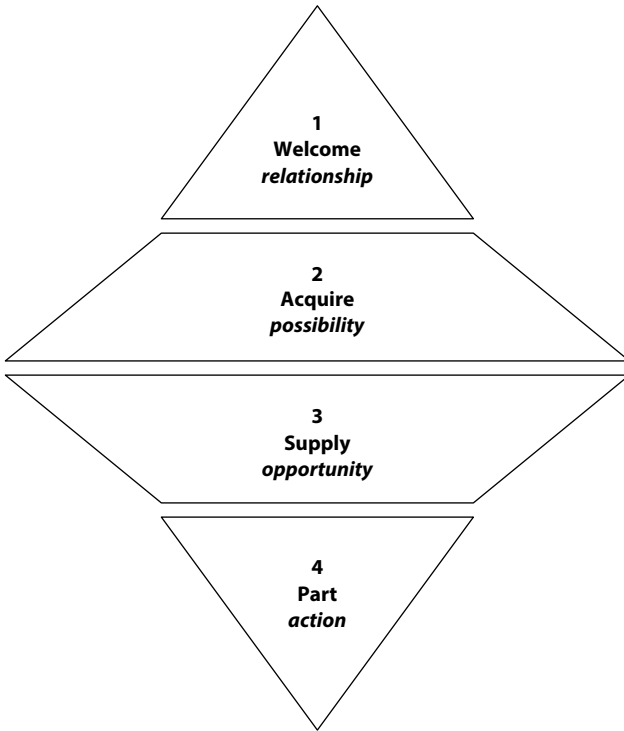
- the past and the present;
- the problem and the solution;
- requests and answers;
- negative ideas and positive ideas;
- opinions about what is true with speculation about the consequences.

Four types of conversation

We can break down the two stages of thinking into four conversations. These are conversations for:

- relationship;
- possibility;
- opportunity;
- action.

These four conversations may form part of a single, larger conversation; they may also take place separately, at different stages of a process or project (see Figure 3.1).

Figure 3.1 Four conversations

A conversation for relationship

This conversation lays the foundation for the other three. We hold this conversation to create or develop the relationship we need in order to achieve our objective.

Key questions in this conversation will include:

- *Who are we?*
- *What is the problem?*
- *How do you define the problem?*
- *How do we relate to the matter in hand?*
- *What links us?*
- *How do we see things?*

- *What do you see that I cannot see?*
- *What do I see that you do not see?*
- *In what ways do we see things similarly, or differently?*

Conversations for relationship may be tentative, awkward or embarrassing. We often rush them. Think of those tricky conversations we hold with strangers at parties. A good conversation for relationship moves beyond the ‘What do you do? Where do you live?’ questions. We are defining our relationship to each other, and how we see the matter in hand.

A conversation for possibility

A conversation for possibility continues the exploration: it develops first-stage thinking. It asks what we *might* be looking at.

Exercise

Key questions in a conversation for possibility include:

- *What is the real problem?*
- *What are we really trying to do?*
- *Is this a problem?*
- *How could we look at this from a different angle?*
- *Can we interpret this differently?*
- *How could we do this?*
- *What does it look like from another person's point of view?*
- *What makes this different from last time?*
- *Have we ever done anything like this before?*
- *Can we make this simpler?*
- *Can we look at this in bits?*
- *What is this like?*
- *What does this feel or look like?*

A conversation for possibility is *not* about whether to do something, or what to do. It seeks to find new ways of looking at the problem.

And, in fact, we could look at any problem in lots of different ways. If you are stuck with a problem, try one of these strategies.

- Look at it from a new angle.
- Ask for different interpretations of what is happening.
- Try to distinguish what you are looking at from what you think about it.
- Ask how other people might see it.
- Break the problem into parts.
- Isolate one part of the problem and look at it in detail.
- Connect the problem into a wider network of ideas.
- Ask what the problem is like. What does it look like, or feel like?

Conversations for possibility can be very creative: brainstorming is a good example. But exploring different points of view can also create conflict: what Edward de Bono calls ‘adversarial thinking’. (More about adversarial thinking shortly and in Chapter 6.)

This isn’t decision time. If you’re chairing a meeting, for example, encourage people to give you ideas, and take care not to judge or criticize either the ideas or the person. Manage the emotional content of this conversation with particular care. Ask, gently, for the evidence to support expressions of feeling.

A conversation for opportunity

A conversation for opportunity takes us into second-stage thinking.

Key questions in this conversation include:

- *Where can we act?*
- *What could we do?*
- *Which possibilities do we build on?*
- *Which possibilities are feasible?*
- *What target do we set ourselves?*

- *Where are the potential obstacles?*
- *How will we know that we have succeeded?*

This conversation focuses on future action: in choosing from among a number of possibilities, you're finding a sense of common purpose. So this conversation is about planning. Many of our good ideas never become reality because we don't map out paths of opportunity. A conversation for opportunity constructs such a path. Assess what you would need to make action possible: resources, support and skills.

Top tip

The bridge from possibility to opportunity is measurement. Begin to set targets and measures of success. If you're talking about a project, where are the milestones – and the obstacles? And how will you measure success?

Backward planning can often be more effective than forward planning. Recall your original objective. Has it changed? Place yourselves in a future where you have achieved your objective. What does such a future look like and feel like? What's happening? What do you need to do to create that future? Backward planning may allow you to simplify the plan and find new opportunities for action.

A conversation for action

In this conversation, you agree what to do, who will do it and when it will happen. Translating opportunity into action needs more than agreement; you need to generate a promise, a *commitment* to act.

A conversation for action is absolutely essential at the end of an interview or meeting. After all, if nothing happens as a result of these conversations, why hold them? A conversation for action balances asking and promising. If necessary, take this conversation step by step.

How to hold a conversation for action

- 1 Ask the other person to do something by a certain time. Make it clear that this is a request, not an order. Orders may get immediate results, but they rarely generate commitment.
- 2 The other person now has four possible answers to this request:
 - They can accept.
 - They can decline.
 - They may commit to accepting or declining at a later date. (*'I'll let you know by...'*)
 - They can make a counter-offer. (*'I can't do that, but I can do...'*)
- 3 Negotiate until the other person is able to make a firm promise. *'I will do x for you by time y.'*

The person making the promise should use this precise wording. Don't settle for a simple 'Yes, I'll do that.' If they *specify* what they will do, and by when – and if they themselves write that action down – then they are more likely to do it. Use this technique to gain commitment to actions at the end of a meeting. If people promise to do something, publicly, and write it down, they are more likely to do what they promise.

These four conversations will only be truly effective if you hold them *in order*. The success of each conversation depends on the success of the conversation before it. If you fail to resolve a conversation, it will continue underneath the next *in code*. Unresolved aspects of a conversation for relationship, for instance, can become conflicts of possibility, hidden agendas or 'personality clashes'. Possibilities left unexplored become lost opportunities. And promises to act that have no real commitment behind them may mean that things do not get done.

Manage your time

Conversations take time, and time is the one entirely non-renewable resource.

Managing time for the conversation

Work out how much time you have. Don't just assume that there is no time. Be realistic. If necessary, make an appointment to hold the interview later, or schedule the meeting for another time.

Top tip

Always be ready to ask the other person if this is a good time to hold this conversation – and how much time they have.

Managing time in the conversation

Most conversations speed up and slow down at different times. Generally, an effective conversation will probably start quite slowly and get faster as it goes on. But there are no real rules about this.

Conversations can go too fast for all sorts of reasons. Paradoxically, agreement and conflict can both cause conversations to speed up. You may have settled on a solution too quickly or have succumbed to 'groupthink' (in which everyone agrees because it feels comforting). Alternatively, a disagreement may have flared into an emotional argument.

Conversely, conversations can become painfully slow when we find ourselves stuck with a problem (or with only one view of a problem). If you hear people analysing the past instead of looking to the future, or people wandering off the subject, it's likely that you need to inject the conversation with new energy.

Exercise

Spend a morning monitoring the pace of your conversations. Which ones went too fast? Which were too slow? During the afternoon, continue monitoring but take action to adjust the pace of the conversation. If the conversation is going too slowly, close down sections of the conversation by summarizing; push for action or move from remarks to implications: 'what does this mean in terms of...?' If the conversation is going too fast, slow it down by reflecting or paraphrasing before responding, by asking open questions (questions beginning with one of the 'w' words – 'why?' is a good candidate) or by simply pausing.

Find common ground

The most satisfying conversations create the sense that we've found common ground. We may have each started in our own territory, with our own points of view; by the end of the conversation, we've found the place where we can stand together, facing the future. To find that place, we may need to move: to change our position, to shift our point of view. Conversation – moving around together – is the means by which we achieve that.

We ask for, and give, permission for these moves to happen. If you are asking permission to move into new territory, you might:

- make a remark tentatively;
- express yourself hesitantly ('Perhaps we might...' 'I suppose I think...' 'It's possible that...');
- pause before speaking;
- look away or look down a lot;
- explicitly ask permission ('Do you mind if I mention...' 'May I speak freely about...');

- make a tentative remark about the other person's words or behaviour.

Don't proceed until the other person has given their permission. They might do so explicitly ('Please say what you like'; 'I would really welcome your honest opinion'; 'I don't mind you talking about that'). Or they might give permission without using words: nodding, smiling, leaning forward.

Conversely, refusing permission can be explicit – 'I'd rather we didn't talk about this' – or in code. The person may evade your question, answer vaguely or reply with another question. Their non-verbal behaviour may hint at their real feelings: folding their arms, sitting back in the chair, becoming restless, evading eye contact.

Move beyond argument

Ask anyone what they think of something, and the chances are they will tell you what's wrong with it. Too often, we assume that arguing for or against an idea is the only way to explore it. Adversarial thinking seems to be deeply engrained in us, perhaps because so many of us learn the skills of debating at school.

A debate is like a verbal boxing match. (The word derives from Latin, 'to beat down'). By the rules of debate, your opinions are somehow proved to be correct if you can successfully discredit any opposing opinions. You don't even have to prove that an idea is wrong; merely by ridiculing or discrediting the person voicing it, you may be able to persuade others that you are right. (This is sometimes called an *ad hominem* argument.)

But argument – however formally conducted – *stops* us exploring and discovering new ideas. And argument can threaten the quality of the conversation itself by raising its emotional temperature: people can become too busy defending themselves, too frightened, too battle fatigued, to do any better.

Top tip

Next time you're asked to comment on an idea, deliberately ask yourself: 'What's good about this idea?'

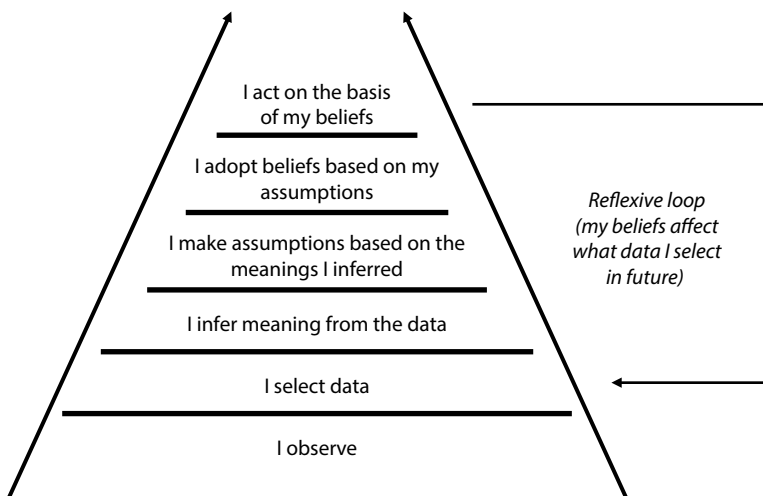
The ladder of inference

The 'ladder of inference' (Figure 3.2) takes our conversations beyond argument. The model was developed initially by Chris Argyris, who pictures the way we think in conversations as a ladder. At the bottom of the ladder is observation; at the top, action.

- From our observation, we step onto the first rung of the ladder by selecting *data*. (We choose what to look at.)
- On the second rung, we infer meaning from our experience of similar data.
- On the third rung, we generalize those meanings into *assumptions*.
- On the fourth rung, we construct mental models (or *beliefs*) out of those assumptions.
- We act on the basis of our mental models.

We travel up and down this ladder whenever we hold a conversation. We're often much better at climbing up than stepping down; in fact, we can leap up all the rungs in a few seconds. These 'leaps of abstraction' allow us to act more quickly but they can also limit the scope of the conversation by creating a belief or mental model that limits our thinking. These beliefs can also send us back *down* the ladder and filter our observations – we select only the data that fits our belief. Argyris calls this a 'reflexive loop'; you might call it a mindset.

The ladder of inference gives us more choices about where to go in a conversation. It *slows down* our thinking. It allows us to:

Figure 3.2 The ladder of inference

- become more aware of our own thinking;
- make that thinking available to others;
- ask others about their thinking.

Above all, we can defuse an adversarial conversation by ‘climbing down’ from private beliefs, assumptions and opinions and then ‘climbing up’ to shared meanings and beliefs.

The key to using the ladder of inference is to ask questions.

- *What is the data that underlies what you have said?*
- *Do we agree on the data?*
- *Do we agree on what they mean?*
- *Can you take me through your reasoning?*
- *When you say [what you have said], do you mean [my rewording of it]?*

For example, if one of us suggests a course of action, the other can carefully climb down the ladder by asking:

- *‘Why do you think this might work?’ ‘What makes this a good plan?’*
- *‘What assumptions do you think you might be making?’ ‘Have you considered...?’*
- *‘How would this affect...?’ ‘Does this mean that...?’*
- *‘Can you give me an example?’ ‘What led you to look at this in particular?’*

Even more powerfully, the ladder of inference can help us to offer our own thinking for the other person to examine. If we’re suggesting a plan of action, we can ask them:

- *‘Can you see any flaws in my thinking?’*
- *‘Would you look at this stuff differently?’ ‘How would you put this together?’*
- *‘Would this look different in different circumstances?’ ‘Are my assumptions valid?’*
- *‘Have I missed anything?’*

The beauty of the ladder of inference is that you don’t need any special training to use it. You can use it immediately, as a practical way to intervene in conversations that may be collapsing into argument.

Exercise

Draw a picture of the ladder of inference on a piece of paper and add some of the questions listed above, near different rungs of the ladder. Put the paper in your wallet or bag – somewhere you can find it easily. Next time you find yourself disagreeing with someone in a conversation, take out the paper and use it to try, deliberately, to climb up or down the ladder. Ask questions; test assumptions; show the links in your own thinking; and ask the other person to show the links in theirs. See where the conversation goes. Then reflect on how useful the ladder of inference was as a conversation tool.

Summarize often

Summaries help us to do everything else we have been discussing in this chapter. They allow us to state our objective and check that we both share the same one. They allow us to structure the conversation and check where we are in our journey through first- and second-stage thinking. They help us to manage time and seek common ground; and they can help us to defuse argument.

Summarizing is not merely repeating what the other person has just said. To summarize means to reinterpret their ideas in your own language. It involves:

- *recognizing* the specific point they have made;
- *appreciating* the position from which they say it;
- *understanding* the beliefs that inform that position.

Recognizing what someone says does not imply that you agree with it. It *does* imply that you're thinking about what they have said. Appreciating their feelings does not mean you feel the same way, but it *does* show that you recognize those feelings. And understanding what they believe may not mean that you share their belief; but it *does* mean that you respect it. All of which means that summaries can contribute to shared problem solving.

Top tip

At the end of a conversation, co-create a summary with the other person.

Use visuals

Many of our conversations have a visual element. Often that element is expressed in our bodies: the way our hand gestures and

facial expressions enrich the meaning of our words. And we can use tools to make our thinking visible: scribbling on the back of an envelope, building a model or running a demonstration.

Meetings, in particular, benefit hugely from using visual tools. A meeting is a group of people thinking together; when we can all see what we're thinking about, we think more efficiently, effectively – and collaboratively. The visual aid focuses our thinking – literally – and we're less inclined to wander off the topic. The more interactive the visual tool, the more it can also help us generate new ideas. A huge range of tools are available: flipcharts and sketchpads, notepads and sticky notes, whiteboards and smartboards, slide decks and interactive screens.

And yet we seem to use these tools very little. In the 2017 Economist Intelligence Unit survey, for example – which we mentioned in the introduction to this book – over half the respondents rated videoconferencing as effective, but only 7 per cent use it daily. Similarly, most respondents recognized the usefulness of presentation decks, white boards and sketch pads – but only 9 per cent use them.

It's a huge wasted opportunity. Visual aids can make meetings more disciplined, more inclusive and more enjoyable. And they don't have to be high tech.

Mind maps are a powerful way to visualize our thinking. In particular, they help us to do first-stage thinking – linking elements and encouraging us to find new ways of looking at something. Mind maps can not only record our thinking, but also improve it.

Exercise

Use this exercise the next time you need to organize your thoughts about a project, a report or a presentation:

- 1 Put a visual image of your subject at the centre of a plain piece of paper.

- 2 Write down anything that comes to mind that connects to the central idea. Don't edit or block any ideas; every idea has the potential to be useful.
- 3 Write single words, in BLOCK CAPITALS, along lines radiating from the centre.

Main ideas will tend to gravitate to the centre of the map;
details will radiate towards the edge.

Every line must connect to at least one other line.

Use visual display: colour, pattern, highlights.

Identify the groups of ideas that you have created. If you wish, give each a heading and put the groups into a number order.

Try out mind maps – in relatively simple conversations to begin with. Record a phone conversation using a mind map and see how well you get on with the technique. Extend your practice to face-to-face conversations and invite the other person to look at and contribute to the map. Many managers use them to record meetings, and as the notes for minute writing.

Using metaphors

Many of the most powerful visuals are created with the words we use. In particular, we can use metaphors. Metaphors are images of ideas in concrete form. The word means 'transferring' or 'carrying over': a metaphor carries your meaning from one thing to another. It enables your listener to see something in a new way, by picturing it as something else. Metaphor uses the imagination to support and develop your ideas.

We use many metaphors without even noticing them. If you want to extend your use of metaphors, start by listening out for them in your everyday conversations.

Exercise

Here is a useful exercise to open up your thinking about a problem. It is especially helpful if you are completely stuck and cannot find any solution.

- 1 Start by writing down the problem. You could define the problem either as a statement of what is wrong, or as a 'how to'.

For example, the problem might be either 'the team isn't working well together' or 'how to help the team work better together'.

- 2 Now ask yourself these questions:
 - What is the problem like?
 - If this were a different situation – a game of cricket, a medieval castle, a mission to Mars, a kindergarten – how would we deal with it?
 - How would a different kind of person manage the issue: a gardener, a politician, an engineer, a hairdresser, an actor?
 - What does this situation feel like?
 - If this problem were an animal, what species of animal would it be?
 - Describe the problem as if it were part of the human body.
- 3 Now try to find connections from the metaphors you have discovered back to the original problem. What does a metaphor suggest about future actions?

You probably need to slow down the conversation to find these metaphors. You will know when you've found a productive metaphor. ('Found' in that sentence is a metaphor.) The conversation will suddenly catch fire (that's another metaphor!). You'll feel a sudden injection of energy (and there's a third metaphor) as you realize that you are looking at the issue in a completely new way.

Summary points

- There are seven proven strategies to help you to improve your conversations:
 - clarify your objective;
 - structure your thinking;
 - manage your time;
 - find common ground;
 - move beyond argument;
 - summarize often;
 - use visuals.
- To clarify your objective:
 - state your objective clearly at the start;
 - ask: problem or solution?
- To structure your thinking:
 - use first-stage thinking and second-stage thinking;
 - hold conversations for: relationship, possibility, opportunity, action.
- To manage your time:
 - manage time for the conversation;
 - manage time in the conversation.
- To find common ground:
 - ask for permission to move onto the other person's territory;
 - give permission for the other person to move onto your territory.
- To move beyond argument:
 - use the ladder of inference to check the other person's thinking;
 - use the ladder of inference to invite the other person to check your thinking.

- Summarize:
 - at the start of the conversation;
 - regularly throughout the conversation;
 - at the end of the conversation.
- Use visuals:
 - record your ideas;
 - use mind maps;
 - use metaphors.

04

The skills of enquiry

The skills of enquiry are the skills of listening. On the ‘push’/‘pull’ spectrum that we explored in Chapter 2, listening is a core ‘pulling’ behaviour. And the quality of any conversation depends on the quality of the listening.

Stephen Covey famously said: ‘Seek first to understand, then to be understood.’ Only by enquiring into someone’s ideas can you respond honestly and fully to them. Only by discovering how they think can you begin to persuade them to your way of thinking. Only by listening can you begin to manage and lead them.

But skilled enquiry also helps the person you’re listening to. Listening – real, deep, attentive listening – can actually help them to think better.

I’ve summarized the skills of enquiry under seven headings:

- paying attention;
- treating the speaker as an equal;
- cultivating ease;
- encouraging;
- asking quality questions;
- rationing information;
- giving positive feedback.

Acquiring these skills will help you to give the other person the respect and space they deserve in order to develop their own ideas – to make their thinking visible.

Paying attention

Paying attention is one of the most respectful things we can do. Paying attention means concentrating on what someone is saying. That sounds simple: how can we listen without paying attention?

Of course, we often do just that. Nancy Kline puts it well, in her book, *Time to Think*:

We think we listen, but we don't. We finish each other's sentences, we interrupt each other, we moan together, we fill in the pauses with our own stories, we look at our watches, we sigh, frown, tap our finger, read the newspaper, or walk away. We give advice, give advice, give advice.

Real listening means pausing our own thinking and allowing the speaker's thinking to enter our mind.

Paying attention helps a speaker to find their ideas and express them. If we're paying proper attention, the speaker will become more articulate. And if we're not paying attention, they'll stumble and hesitate. Poor attention makes them more stupid; close attention makes them more intelligent.

Don't rush. Adjust your own tempo to that of the other person. Wait longer than you want to. And when they can't think of anything else to say, ask: 'What else do you think about this? What else can you think of? What else comes to mind?' That invitation to talk more can bring even the weariest brain back to life.

Interrupting

Interrupting is the most obvious symptom of poor attention. Sometimes, we can't resist it. Some demon inside us seems to

compel us to fill the speaker's pauses with words. It's as if the very idea of silence terrifies us.

Mostly, we interrupt because we're making assumptions. Next time you interrupt someone in a conversation, ask yourself which of these assumptions you are applying.

- My idea is better than theirs.
- The answer is more important than the problem.
- I have to utter my idea fast and if I don't interrupt, I'll lose my chance (or forget it).
- I know what they are going to say.
- They don't need to finish the sentence because my rewrite is an improvement.
- They can't improve this idea any further, so I might as well improve it for them.
- I'm more important than they are.
- It is more important for me to be seen to have a good idea than for me to let them finish.
- Interrupting will save time.

If you're assuming you know what the speaker is about to say, you're probably wrong. If you allow them to continue, they will often come up with something more interesting, more vivid and more personal.

Exercise

Next time you hold a conversation with a colleague, deliberately note down the number of times you interrupt them – and the number of times they interrupt you. When the conversation has finished, count up the two totals. What do the numbers suggest? How many of those interruptions were useful or necessary? (Not every interruption is unhelpful.)

Allowing quiet

Once you stop interrupting, the conversation will become quieter. Pauses will appear. The other person will stop talking and you will not fill the silence.

Think of these pauses as junctions in the your conversation's journey. You have a number of choices about where you might go next. Either of you might choose. If you want to switch from listening to persuading, you might make the choice. But, if you're enquiring, then you give the speaker the privilege of making the choice.

Top tip

There are two kinds of pause. One is a filled pause; the other is empty. Learn to distinguish between the two.

Some pauses are filled with thought. Sometimes, the speaker will stop, perhaps suddenly. They'll look elsewhere, probably into a longer distance. They are busy on an excursion – and you're not invited. But they will want you to be there at the junction when they come back. You're privileged that they have trusted you to wait. So wait.

The other kind of pause is an empty one. Nothing much is happening. The speaker does not stop suddenly; instead, they seem to fade away. You're standing at the junction in the conversation together, and neither of you is moving. The energy seems to drop out of the conversation. The speaker's eyes don't focus anywhere. If they're comfortable in your company, they may focus on you as a cue for you to choose what move to make.

Wait out the pause. If the pause is empty, the speaker will probably say so in a few moments. 'I can't think of anything else.' 'That's it, really.' 'So. There we are. I'm stuck now.' Try asking: 'Can you think of anything else?' If the other person is ready for you to take the lead, then do so: ask a question, make a suggestion.

Showing that you are paying attention

The best way to look as if you are paying attention is – well, to pay attention. But sometimes we need to consciously work at paying attention. Begin with your eyes: practise looking steadily at the speaker when you're listening to them, and start to notice when you glance away. Generally, we don't look nearly enough at the people we listen to.

Working on our eye movements benefits both listener and speaker. If you look more attentively, you'll actually pay more attention to what the speaker is saying. (The speaker will probably look away from you more frequently; it's what we do when we're thinking about what to say.) Relax your facial muscles: no frowns or rigid smiles. Use minimal encouragers (more about those in the section on 'encouraging' below.) But come back, always, to the way you use your eyes.

Be aware that such attentive looking may actually inhibit the speaker. In some cultures, looking equates to staring and signals disrespect. You need to be sensitive to these possible individual or cultural distinctions and adapt your eye movements accordingly.

Treating the speaker as an equal

You'll enquire well only if you raise the other person's status. 'Pushing' behaviour, which raises our status, will always lower the other person's status (look back at Chapter 2). That will interrupt their thinking, and may mean that you never discover valuable information and ideas.

For managers and leaders, status in conversations is often complicated by power. Power can come in many different forms: the power to reward or punish, for example; the power deriving from regulation or expertise; the power conferred by a senior role. When power combines with status-raising 'push' behaviours, we can easily find ourselves becoming patronizing.

Patronizing the speaker is the greatest enemy of equality in conversations. It grows out of the way parents and carers treat children (the word comes from the Latin word ‘pater’, meaning ‘father’). Of course, we often have to treat children like children. We need to:

- direct them;
- control them;
- think for them.

If you’re a manager, you might see that list as a more or less comprehensive list of your responsibilities towards the people you manage. And you might think that the way to discharge those responsibilities is to talk. But wise managers – and leaders – know that there’s far more to be gained from listening than from talking.

As soon as you think you know better than the other person, or provide the answers for them, you’re patronizing them. You cannot patronize someone and pay them close attention at the same time.

Cultivating ease

Good thinking happens in a relaxed environment. Cultivating ease will allow you to enquire more deeply, and discover more ideas. When you are at ease, the solution to a problem will sometimes appear as if by magic.

Many people are uncomfortable with the idea of ease at work. They’re so used to urgency that they cannot imagine working in any other way. Many organizations equate ease with sloth. If you’re not working flat out, chasing deadlines and juggling 50 assignments at the same time, you’re not worth your salary. It’s sometimes assumed that the best thinking happens in such a climate.

Not so. Urgency keeps people from thinking well; they’re too busy *doing*. After all, doing is what gets results, isn’t it? Well, not when people have to think to get those results. Sometimes, the best

results only appear by *not* doing: by paying attention to someone else's ideas with a mind that's alert and at ease.

Cultivating ease is a behavioural skill. You don't have to *feel* at ease to promote ease in another person. (How would you speak to a person who is threatening you with a gun, for example?) Breathe out, slow down your speaking rhythm, lower the volume and the pitch of your voice. Banish distractions: unplug the phone, close the door, find somewhere quiet and comfortable. (You may need to leave the office.) Make time. If the time isn't right, postpone the conversation.

Encouraging

In order to liberate the other person's ideas, you may need to do more than pay attention, treat them as an equal and cultivate ease. You may need to actively encourage them to give you their ideas.

We're back with that key question we discovered in Chapter 1: *What effect am I having?* The speaker's thinking is largely the result of the effect you are having on them. So if you:

- suggest that they change the subject;
- try to convince them of your point of view before listening to their point of view;
- reply tit-for-tat to their remarks; or
- encourage them to compete with you,

you're not encouraging them to develop their thinking. You're not enquiring properly.

One of the worst enemies of encouragement is competitiveness. We can so easily find ourselves using the speaker's ideas to promote our own. It's all part of that habit of adversarial thinking.

Competition forces people to think only those thoughts that will help them win. If the speaker feels that you're competing with them, they'll not only say less, but think less. Conversely, if you feel that the speaker is trying to compete with you, don't allow yourself

to enter the competition. The ladder of inference (see Chapter 3) is one very powerful tool that will help you to defuse competitiveness in your conversations.

Instead of competing, welcome the difference in your points of view. Then try to find common ground. (Look back at Chapter 3.)

Minimal encouragers

Minimal encouragers are brief, supportive actions that show the speaker that you want them to continue. They can be:

- sub-vocalizations: 'uh-huh', 'mm';
- words and phrases: 'right', 'really?', 'I see';
- repeated key words.

Behaviours can include:

- leaning forward;
- focusing eye contact;
- head nodding.

Minimal encouragers support the speaker without interrupting them. They demonstrate your interest, both generally and in particular points that the speaker is making. But beware: they could subtly influence the speaker to say what they think you want to hear, rather than what they want to say. And, poorly used, they can signal impatience or become an empty gesture.

Asking quality questions

Questions are at the heart of enquiry. That's obvious: enquiring *is* asking a question.

But, of course, questions can do much more than enquire: we can use them to spark an argument or to make ourselves look

clever. Questions can be statements in disguise; we can use them to criticize, ridicule or even insult.

It's not always considered good form to ask questions. We may stop ourselves asking a question because we fear challenging authority, or looking stupid. In some organizations, asking questions is simply 'not done'. 'Questioning,' said Samuel Johnson on one occasion, 'is not the mode of conversation among gentlemen.'

The best questions open up the speaker's thinking. A question that helps them to think further, develop an idea or clarify a thought, is a high-quality question. So use questions to:

- find out facts;
- check your understanding;
- help the other person to improve their understanding;
- invite the other person to examine your own thinking;
- request action.

A whole repertoire of questions is available to help you to enquire more fully. Specifically, we can use six types of questions.

- *Closed questions* can only be answered 'yes' or 'no'.
- *Open questions* cannot be answered 'yes' or 'no'.
- *Leading questions* put the answer into the other person's mouth.
- *Controlling questions* help you to take the lead in the conversation.
- *Probing questions* build on an earlier question, or dig deeper.
- *Reflecting questions* restate the last remark but with no new request.

Remember also the ladder of inference from Chapter 3. This powerful tool can provide all sorts of questions. You can also use it to invite the speaker to ask you questions.

One particular kind of question is especially powerful. It can liberate the speaker's thinking by removing the assumptions that limit it. This magic question starts with two words: 'What if'.

Guess an assumption that the speaker might be making and then ask either, ‘What if this assumption weren’t true?’ or ‘What if the opposite assumption were true?’

Examples of the first kind of question might include:

- *What if you became chief executive tomorrow?*
- *What if I weren’t your manager?*
- *What if you weren’t limited in your use of equipment?*

Examples of the second kind might include:

- *What if you weren’t limited by a budget?*
- *What if customers were actually flocking to us?*
- *What if you knew that you were vital to the company’s success?*

Exercise

Next time you prepare for a fact-finding conversation – an appraisal interview, perhaps, or a project update – make a list of the questions you could ask. Try to include at least one of every type: closed, open, leading, controlling, probing, reflecting, ‘what if’. Think about a possible order for these questions, and how some questions might be alternatives or potential questions, depending on the direction the conversation takes.

Rationing information

Information is power. Withholding information can be a power move, putting you at an advantage over the other person. But offering *too much* information can also interfere with enquiry: it can stop the other person thinking effectively. So it helps, in enquiry mode, to *ration* the information you give.

- *Don't interrupt.* Let the speaker finish before giving any new information. Don't force information into the middle of their sentence.
- *Time your intervention.* Ask yourself when the most appropriate time might be to offer the information.
- *Filter the information.* Only offer information that you think will improve the speaker's thinking. Resist the temptation to amplify some piece of information that's not central to their thinking.
- *Don't give information to show off.* You may be tempted to give information to demonstrate how expert or up to date you are. Resist that temptation.

Top tip

Ask the other person what information they need to know before you start to offer what *you* think they need to know.

You can also ration the amount of information you ask the speaker to give you. Ask for information at the right time and for the right reason; better to let the speaker work out their own ideas and then ask for a summary, than to keep interrupting them with questions.

Giving positive feedback

At its simplest, we use feedback to check that we've understood. But feedback can do more: it can help us to switch from listening to speaking – from enquiry to persuasion, perhaps. It can prepare us to move from first-stage to second-stage thinking, from problem to solution. And feedback can reinforce the speaker's sense of self-worth, which can lead to improved performance.

For many managers, of course, feedback is often not the *result* of a listening conversation, but the *reason* for holding the

conversation in the first place. Many managers find performance feedback stressful, especially if they fear a hostile response from the employee. In the survey commissioned by the Interact consultancy in 2016, over a third of managers (37 per cent) claimed to feel uncomfortable giving performance feedback to which the employee might respond negatively.

This anxiety impels the manager to get through the meeting as quickly as possible. That's understandable: we're programmed to avoid pain. But the result is a conversation in which the manager does nearly all the talking and the employee remains silent. It's all 'push': no enquiry, no listening, no real attention.

Now consider the effect of this conversation on the employee. In a survey of almost 4,000 people, Jack Zenger and Joseph Folkman found that people's attitude to feedback alters significantly according to how well they feel listened to. The less people felt their managers listened to them, the more likely they were to believe that the feedback was dishonest. In particular, employees who felt that their managers didn't listen to them were significantly less happy to receive negative feedback.

The conclusion's clear. Performance feedback works best when the manager begins by listening to the employee.

Top tip

Consider the classic opening line of a feedback meeting: 'Come in and close the door, I want to talk to you.' Imagine it rewritten as: 'Please come in and close the door; I want to listen to you.'

Whether you're managing or not, the best kind of feedback is *genuine, succinct and specific*. And, of course, it can have those qualities only if you've listened well.

Choose carefully when to give your feedback. If in doubt, ask whether it is appropriate to start your feedback or whether the speaker wants to continue. Ask:

- for permission to feed back;
- how the speaker sees the situation in summary;
- what the speaker sees as the key issue or problem.

Only then should you launch into your own feedback.

Balancing appreciation and criticism

There are two kinds of feedback: positive and negative.

We often assume that negative feedback is more realistic than positive feedback. ‘Get real’, we might say to justify criticism. We might assume that positive feedback – saying what we like about an idea – is naive and simplistic. Years of training and experience in critical thinking may have taught us not to comment on what we approve or like.

Actually, of course, the positive aspects of reality can be just as realistic as the negative ones. Adding positive feedback to the negative doesn’t distort our view of reality; it adds to it.

Top tip

You can discover a source of positive feedback simply by asking yourself, ‘What’s good about this idea?’ You could even ask the speaker the same question. The answer will nearly always reveal something that you had not noticed before. And that can form the basis for positive feedback.

We can transform negative into positive feedback by using the phrase ‘how to’. For example, if the other person is suggesting doing something and you want to say, ‘We simply don’t have the resources to do this’, you could rephrase the remark by asking ‘How could we do this with the limited resources we have?’ If you want to say ‘You haven’t thought this through’, you could ask ‘How can we develop this idea more thoroughly?’

Those two simple words – ‘how to’ – can have a magical effect on the quality of your feedback.

Exercise

Spend one day noting down all your responses to ideas from other people. How many times were your comments negative – in other words, expressing what you didn't like about something or what you thought was wrong with the idea? How many comments were positive – expressing what you liked about the idea or what you thought was good about it? How could you transform the negative comments into positive ones? Could you, for example, turn a criticism into a ‘how could we’ question?

Summary points

- There are seven key skills of enquiry:
 - paying attention;
 - treating the speaker as an equal;
 - cultivating ease;
 - encouraging;
 - asking quality questions;
 - rationing information;
 - giving positive feedback.
- To pay attention:
 - listen;
 - don't interrupt;
 - allow quiet;
 - show that you are paying attention.

- To treat the speaker as an equal:
 - give equal turns to speak and listen;
 - don't tell them what to say;
 - don't assume that you know what they mean better than they do.
- To cultivate ease:
 - find time;
 - make space;
 - banish distractions.
- To encourage:
 - don't compete in the conversation;
 - explore differences of opinion;
 - use minimal encouragers.
- Ask quality questions to help you:
 - find out facts;
 - check your understanding;
 - help the other person to improve their understanding;
 - invite the other person to examine your own thinking;
 - request action.
- To ration information:
 - don't interrupt;
 - time your intervention;
 - filter the information;
 - don't give information to show off.
- To give positive feedback:
 - balance appreciation and criticism;
 - assume constructive intent;
 - feed back on specifics.

05

The skills of persuasion

Communication begins with understanding and continues with being understood. And being understood will always involve an element of persuasion.

If enquiry uses the skills of listening, then persuasion foregrounds the skills of speaking. On the ‘push’/‘pull’ spectrum we looked at in Chapter 2, persuasion would seem to be very much a ‘push’ behaviour.

The ability to persuade has never been in more demand. Managing a team, marketing a product, leading an organization – there are few areas of corporate life where the skills of persuasion are not vital. We need to be able to persuade especially in situations where we lack managerial authority: working on project teams; liaising with external partners or suppliers; collaborating on boards or committees. If we have no power to instruct, we’ll need to employ the power of persuasion.

This magical talent has been the subject of study for thousands of years. The classical Greeks called it *rhetoric*: the earliest manual that survives is by Aristotle. In the Middle Ages and the Renaissance, rhetoric was core curriculum in European schools and universities; Shakespeare’s genius, for example, is underpinned by a solid rhetorical training.

These days, few of us study rhetoric; but the great tradition still has plenty to teach us about influencing and persuading. To return yet again to that first question – *What effect am I having?* – rhetoric teaches us how to create a wide range of different effects.

In particular, rhetoric shows us that persuasion works both consciously and unconsciously. We might call the unconscious element ‘influence’. (Vance Packard’s famous 1957 book, *The Hidden Persuaders*, explored subliminal influence in advertising and the media.) The most successful persuasion always includes a great deal of influencing.

Historically, rhetoric has been more concerned with oratory than with conversations. As a result, we often talk about persuading an *audience* rather than an individual, and we’ll be using that word in this chapter. But whenever you see the word ‘audience’ here, it applies equally to an individual and a group.

Character, logic and passion

Aristotle suggested that persuasion combined three skills. A speaker could appeal to his audience (in classical rhetoric, the speaker was almost always male) by establishing a good reputation with them, by using logic and by stirring their emotions. Aristotle famously named these three skills *ethos*, *logos* and *pathos*. He was writing about orators: politicians, lawyers and generals addressing huge crowds of Athenian citizens. But his model has just as much to teach a manager speaking at a meeting, or a call-centre team answering customer queries.

Character (*ethos*)

We tend to believe people we believe to be ‘of good character’ – people we trust or respect. *Ethos* is the skill of establishing that trust and fostering that respect. The key question in working on *ethos* is: why should your audience believe you?

Aristotle suggested that *ethos* itself comprises three skills.

- First, demonstrate that you share your audience's values. If you can show that your beliefs, priorities and attitudes align to those of your audience, they'll feel that you're one of them.
- Second, display practical common sense. Indicate that you know something about how the real world operates, and that textbook solutions don't always work out in practice. Favour the middle way; reject extremes.
- And third, demonstrate that you've invested personally in the idea you're arguing for. What have you done to contribute to making this proposition successful? Better still, what have you sacrificed?

Exercise

The next time you're preparing to make a case to a manager or team, put the argument to one side briefly, and note down how you can increase your *ethos*. How can you demonstrate that you share your manager's values? How can you demonstrate practical good sense and moderation? How can you demonstrate a sense of personal commitment to your proposal?

Logic (*logos*)

Logic is apparently the work of rational thought, rather than unconscious influence. By using *logos*, we're appealing to our audience's ability to reason. We construct an argument by making a case, and creating reasons to support that case. Reasons are linked to the case by logic.

But logic is only *apparently* conscious and rational. Every argument is based on assumptions, and those assumptions – by definition – are unconscious. If your argument is based on assumptions that your audience doesn't share, then no amount of logical

argumentation will succeed in persuading them. (More about logic later in this chapter.)

Passion (pathos)

Pathos persuades by appealing to the parts of our audience that rational argument can't reach. The pathetic appeal is usually defined as an appeal to the emotions. Emotions provoke us to act without needing to think: that's why we say that we feel *moved* when in the grip of an emotion.

If we want to persuade, we *must* engage our audience's feelings. It may feel manipulative, but ignoring the emotions is likely to make us look cold and inhuman. (Mr Spock on *StarTrek* continually had this problem when trying to persuade his colleagues to act rationally.) Our rhetorical aim must be to stimulate the feeling appropriate to the action we want our audience to take.

Pathos, however, does more than arouse emotion. Anything that influences our audience's feelings contributes to the pathetic appeal: stories, for example, or examples that excite the imagination. *Pathos* ultimately seeks to create a sense of identification in the audience: with you, with your idea, and – especially if your audience is a group of people – a sense of identification with themselves. (There is more about the power of *pathos* later in this chapter, in the section on expressing your ideas.)

Six principles of influence

Professor Robert Cialdini, in his bestseller *Influence: The science of persuasion*, identifies six patterns of influence, all of which operate unconsciously. Any one of them can enhance the pathetic appeal:

- *Reciprocity: the old give and take (and take)*

We feel a strong urge to repay a favour. Offer your audience a gift – or a concession – and they may feel moved to do what you want.

- *Authority: directed deference*
We're easily moved by people whose authority we recognize.
(Here, *pathos* meets *ethos*.)
- *Scarcity: less is more*
We're motivated to reach for something we think is in short supply. We're also motivated more by the prospect of losing something than gaining something. Point out what your audience might lose and you'll strike an emotional chord.
- *Consistency: I am what I say*
We want to be seen to be consistent with past behaviours. Show that what you want someone to do aligns with something they have done or said in the past.
- *Alignment: truths are us*
We're strongly influenced to feel and do what we know people around us are feeling and doing. Persuading people as a group can often be more successful than seeking to persuade them individually.
- *Liking: I like you, you're like me*
We would all prefer to say 'yes' to someone we know and like. Exploit your similarity to your audience: in your actions, in your words, even perhaps in the way you dress.

(Remember these six patterns with the mnemonic RASCAL.)

You must use all three of these qualities – good character, logic and passion – if you want to persuade successfully. The *process* of working out how to persuade them consists of five key elements:

- identifying the core idea;
- arranging your ideas logically;
- developing an appropriate style in the language you use;
- remembering your ideas;
- delivering your ideas with words, visual cues and non-verbal behaviour.

What's the Big Idea?

What do you want to say? A single idea is more likely to persuade your listener than a group of ideas, simply because one strong idea is easier to remember.

Take time to find that Big Idea. Conduct imaginary conversations in your head and note down the kind of things you might say. Now ask three questions.

- ‘*What is my objective?*’ What do I want to achieve? What would I like to see happen?
- ‘*Who am I talking to?*’ Why am I talking to this person about this objective? What do they already know? What more do they need to know? What do I want them to do? What ideas are likely to convince them?
- ‘*What is the most important thing I have to say to them?*’ If I were only allowed a few minutes with them, what would I say? What if I had only a few *seconds* to get my Big Idea across? (Film executives call this ‘the elevator pitch’. Imagine that you were in the lift with your listener for a few seconds between floors.)

Top tip

Write down your Big Idea as a single sentence. You cannot express an idea without uttering a sentence. Does this sentence express what you want to say clearly and coherently? Now learn it by heart!

Now test your Big Idea. If you were to speak this sentence to your listener, would they ask you a question? If you’re arguing a point, your Big Idea should provoke the question ‘Why?’

You may need to prepare your listener for your Big Idea. You may need to fill them in on some background, set the context

or focus their attention. This means doing a bit of unconscious influencing: some *ethos*, perhaps, and a dash of *pathos*.

A neat way to pull all this together can be to tell a story. Biljana Scott, in a paper for the organization Diplo, puts it well:

The Greek concept of pathos, although defined as ‘the appeal to emotion for rhetorical effect’, tends to include within its remit imagination, identification and a sense of fellow suffering (pathos means both ‘suffering’ and ‘experience’); all defining components of a gripping story.

Here is a simple four-point structure that you can use to construct that story. I remember it by using the letters SPQR (which is the motto of the Roman Empire).

Situation

Briefly tell the listener something they already know. You’re showing that you understand their situation and can appreciate their point of view. (That’s *ethos* at work.) You are also showing that you identify with them. (There’s the touch of *pathos*.) The Situation statement might begin with ‘Once upon a time’, ‘We all know that’, or ‘Everyone here agrees that’. It sets the scene for the rest of the story.

Problem

Now identify a Problem that has arisen within the Situation. The Problem complicates the Situation in some way: it sets up the tension without which you wouldn’t have a story.

Unlike the Situation, the Problem will probably be new information for your listener. And it should make them pay attention. This is something they need to know about. It really should be *their* problem.

Problems come in all shapes and sizes. Something may have gone wrong, or be threatening to go wrong. Something may have changed (or not changed). We may not know what to do; we may be facing a range of options from which we must choose.

Don't forget the *pathos* at this point. Negative problems might arouse fear or concern; opportunities should arouse a sense of excitement.

Question

The Problem should prompt your listener to ask a Question. You should aim to generate the Question that allows you to deliver your Big Idea. Tell the story to maximize your chances that your listener asks that very Question.

Situation	Problem	Question
Stable, agreed status quo	Something has gone wrong	What do we do?
	Something could go wrong	How do we stop it?
	Something has changed	How do we adjust to it?
	Something could change	How do we prepare for it?
	Something new has arisen	What can we do?
	Someone has a different point of view	Who is right?
	We don't know what to do	What do we do? (or) How do we choose?
	There are a number of things we could do	Which course do we take?

Response

Your Response to the Question should be your Big Idea. Your listener should now be ready to consider that idea because it answers a question that *they* have asked.

SPQR is a classic storytelling framework. It's also a method that management consultants use in the introductions to their proposals. The trick is to tell the story *quickly*. Don't be tempted to fill out the story with lots of detail. Focus on what interests the listener.

You're influencing them, not yet persuading them. Keep your listener's attention by reflecting what they know, as well as their values, priorities and concerns.

Arranging your ideas logically

Logic is the glue that binds ideas into arguments. In its most basic form, an argument consists of three elements:

- a *claim* (the point you are arguing for);
- a *reason* (a statement that supports the claim);
- and the word '*because*'.

All the logic in your argument is tied up in that simple word: *because*. Most business arguments are best constructed as pyramids. The Big Idea – or claim – sits at the top of the pyramid and is supported by a small group of other ideas that act as reasons.

Look back at the Big Idea you've worked on. A persuasive Big Idea – a claim that you're arguing for – should be worded in such a way as to provoke the question 'Why?' Your task now is to find a group of reasons that answer the question.

For example, if your Big Idea is 'We should invest in System X', then the supporting reasons might be:

- System X is the most effective system of its kind.
- System X is cheaper than its immediate competitors.
- System X will integrate well with our existing systems.

Constructing an argument in this way – as a pyramid with a small number of reasons supporting a single claim – is usually called *inductive logic*. It's a good way to present a business argument because it presents the main idea first, and then supports it – always a useful strategy when seeking to persuade busy people.

Top tip

This pyramid technique also works for explanations. If your Big Idea is explaining a point, find the small number of ideas that support or explain the point more fully.

Of course, you may need to go on to present evidence for each of your reasons. And your audience will need to believe that evidence.

Checking assumptions

Every argument is based on assumptions. Like most assumptions, they're implicit or unspoken – we probably won't even notice them. Surfacing and testing those assumptions is a critical step in constructing a persuasive argument.

Let's take a very simple argument and analyse it. If you say 'Eat more vegetables because they're good for you', the statement before '*because*' is your claim, and the statement after it is your reason.

How persuasive is this argument? It depends who you're trying to persuade.

The strength of any argument depends on the assumptions underlying it. If we agree with the assumption that we should always do what's good for our health, then we're likely to accept the argument that we should eat more vegetables. A medical student, for example, might accept the assumption but then demand evidence that vegetables are indeed good for us. A child, in contrast, probably wouldn't be interested in their personal health, and with them the argument is likely to fail.

Many logical arguments fail – in the home, in the media and in the workplace – because the audience doesn't share the assumptions underlying them. We see this mismatch most vividly in political or religious arguments, but you'll spot it also in business meetings, interviews and sales conversations. If you're arguing a

case, pay close attention to the assumptions that underlie it. Does your audience share them?

Expressing your ideas

When we express our ideas, we need to combine the rational *logos* of our argument with the emotional and imaginative appeal of *pathos*. Pictures may work better than words: if you want your audience to donate to an animal charity, show them a picture of an animal in distress (better still, bring an animal on stage with you). The appeal to the senses is not restricted to visual images, of course; think about how any of the five senses might respond to your Big Idea.

Examples

Perhaps the simplest way to bring an idea alive is to offer a concrete example. Audiences are more likely to be persuaded by a single example than a raft of statistics. A good example will also show that you know your stuff, and that you can apply it to real life (a key element of *ethos*). Find an instance where the idea has been put into practice, or where it has created real results – either useful or disastrous.

Convincing examples have three key characteristics.

- First, they usually include real people doing real things. Can you give an example of someone doing something that illustrates your Big Idea?
- Second, they include vivid description, which stimulates one or more of the five senses. What does this example sound like, look like, feel, smell or taste like?
- And third, convincing examples involve feeling or emotion. Talk about how pleased the client was, how relieved you were, how excited you are by this idea.

Using metaphors

Metaphors can be powerful persuaders. As we saw towards the end of Chapter 3, metaphors express one thing in terms of another; by linking a topic to something the listener already knows about, you create a bridge that allows them to cross over into your thinking.

You could use metaphors to capture your listener's imagination or stimulate their feelings. You can also use them in a more extended way, to explain a complicated or unusual topic. But if you do intend to use a metaphor in this extended way, you need to think carefully about the metaphor you choose.

The best metaphors clarify complex topics, rather than confusing the listener. For example, Dana Meadows, one of the gurus of systems theory, explains feedback loops using the metaphor of filling a glass with water. You turn on the tap, you watch the water level rise, and as it nears the top of the glass you regulate the flow of water. When the glass is full, you turn off the tap. This metaphor allows us to think more widely about feedback loops. For example, if you cannot see the glass, or if the flow of water is too fast, operating the feedback loop will be more difficult.

To find the right metaphor, start with your audience.

- What do you know about what they know?
- What do you want them to be able to do as a result of understanding the topic?
- What aspects of your topic do you want to explain?
- What else in the world shares the qualities you are trying to explain?
- Experiment with the metaphor and see how far you can extend it.
- Review your choice. Are you making the topic easier to understand?

Remembering your ideas

Memory played a vital role in the art of rhetoric in the days before printing. With no easy means of making notes orators had to remember what to say, and in what order. Whole systems of memory were invented to help them.

These days, the art of memory has been replaced by technology – except, perhaps, for passing examinations. We have no *need* to remember; merely to read and store emails, pick up messages on the mobile, plug in, surf and download.

But memory still plays an important part in persuading others. No one was ever persuaded by watching someone recite from a sheaf of notes (or from a series of slides).

Find a way to bring the ideas off paper and into your head. Give yourself some clear mental signposts so that you can find your way from one idea to the next. Have a way of *showing* your thoughts as you explain them: a notepad, a flipchart, a whiteboard.

Top tip

Invite the other person to join in the visualizing process: encourage them to think of this as the shape of *their* thinking as much as yours.

Delivering effectively

You are as much a part of the persuasive process as your argument, your examples and your stories. If you're saying one thing but your body is saying another, no one will believe your words.

Start, as ever, with the person you're trying to persuade. Do they favour a relaxed, informal conversational style, or a more formal, presentational delivery? Are they interested in the broad picture or lots of supporting detail? Will they want to ask questions?

Delivery is broadly about three kinds of activity. Think about the way you use your eyes, voice and body.

Effective eye contact

We speak more with our eyes than with our voices. Maintain eye contact with your listener. If you're talking to more than one person, include everyone with your eyes. Focus on their eyes; don't look through them.

Using your voice

Your voice will sound more persuasive if it's not too high, too fast or too thin. Regulate and strengthen your breathing while you speak. Breathe deep and slow. Let your voice emerge more from your body than from your throat. The more body that your voice has, and the more measured your vocal delivery, the more convincing you'll sound.

You can find more tips on breathing in Chapter 7. Meanwhile, try this exercise.

Exercise

Here's how to find the best version of your voice. (Thanks to Caroline Goyder for this exercise.) Put your thumb just below where your ribs separate (just below where the front of a bra strap goes – if you wear one). You are feeling for a layer of muscle: massage it gently and feel it soften. Now gently tap that point and let out a big belly laugh. Or yawn loudly. Feel how the sound of your voice drops down and becomes more relaxed. Jump up and down and speak. Become aware of how your voice is coming from your centre – almost up from your lower spine. *That's* the voice you're looking for. Everyone has it; we just need to find it. Once you have done this exercise, try singing what you

want to say. Listen to how your voice shifts between speaking and singing. You are aiming to locate the source of your voice between your chest and your stomach – not your throat.

Persuasive body language

Your face, your limbs and your body posture all contribute to the total persuasive effect. Keep your facial muscles moving and your neck muscles relaxed. Use your hands to paint pictures, to help you find the right words and express yourself fully.

Professional persuaders observe their listeners' behaviour and quietly mirror it. If you're relaxed with the other person, that mirroring will tend to happen naturally: you may find that you're crossing your legs in similar ways or moving your arms in roughly the same way. Try consciously to adapt your own posture and movement to that of your listener. Do more: take the lead. Don't sit back or close your body off when you're seeking to persuade; bring yourself forward, open yourself up and present *yourself*, along with your ideas.

Summary points

- We can persuade by using:
 - *ethos*: appealing to our audience's sense of our character or reputation;
 - *logos*: appealing to their reason;
 - *pathos*: appealing to their emotions.
- *Ethos* is the appeal to our audience through:
 - personality;
 - reputation;
 - personal credibility.

- *Logos* appeals to rational thinking by using logic.
- *Pathos* is the appeal to emotions or feelings:
 - The pathetic appeal must always be indirect.
 - Pathos should never be dishonest.
 - Provoke the feeling that is appropriate to the action you want the audience to take.
- The *process* of working out how to persuade them consists of five key elements:
 - Identifying the core idea.
 - Arranging your ideas logically.
 - Developing an appropriate style in the language you use.
 - Remembering your ideas.
 - Delivering your ideas with words, visual cues and non-verbal behaviour.
- To identify the core idea, ask:
 - ‘What is my objective?’
 - ‘Who am I talking to?’
 - ‘What is the most important thing I have to say to them?’
- The message sentence should be:
 - a single idea;
 - no longer than about 15 words;
 - action-centred;
 - self-contained;
 - attention-grabbing.
- To arrange your ideas logically:
 - Ask what question your message provokes: ‘Why?’ ‘How?’ ‘Which ones?’
 - Use SPQR to introduce your message and fill in the background.
 - Use inductive logic to arrange your supporting ideas.

- To express your ideas more vividly, use:
 - images;
 - examples;
 - metaphors.
- To remember your material, use visual aids such as:
 - mind maps;
 - flipcharts;
 - whiteboards.
- And to deliver your ideas well:
 - maintain effective eye contact;
 - use your voice well;
 - make your body language persuasive.

06

Tough conversations

At some point in your career, you'll have to hold a tough conversation. It goes, as they say, with the territory. Any book about improving your communication skills should help you with the conversations you struggle with. (Of course, we also have to hold tough conversations outside work. This book focuses on communication in the workplace, but the skills we discuss are applicable in personal conversations too.)

To misquote Tolstoy: all happy conversations are alike; all tough conversations are tough in their own way. When conversations go well, it's usually for similar reasons: rapport is high, we're talking the same language, and the conversation's objective is clear. In contrast, conversations can become tough for different reasons. Some are predictable; many take us completely by surprise.

Six tough conversations

Holly Weeks sets out six broad types of tough conversation in her book, *Failure to Communicate*. You'll probably recognize all six.

- *I've got bad news.* Every manager, at some point, will need to tell someone something they don't want to hear.
- *You're challenging my power.* The opposite, in some ways, of the previous conversation: you need to raise a problem with your manager, and you're worried that they may feel threatened.

- *I can't go there.* If you are conflict-averse, you may try to avoid the tough conversation – and make it tougher.
- *You win/I lose.* You're trying to be cooperative and the other person insists on making it competitive – and trying to win.
- *What's going on here?* A calm conversation suddenly becomes charged with negative emotion. Perhaps an innocent remark has been taken entirely the wrong way, with catastrophic consequences.
- *I'm being attacked.* The other person in the conversation suddenly starts accusing, shouting, threatening or being abusive.

What makes conversations tough?

Difficult conversations become tough when they develop three features. First, we sense – sometimes suddenly, shockingly – that we don't understand what's going on. In particular, we have no idea why the other person is behaving as they are. Second, emotion rears its head, clouding our judgement and dictating all sorts of unhelpful tactics. Among those tactics is the third key feature of a tough conversation: conflict.

Each of these three elements can cause us to choose tactics that can make the conversation tougher.

The fog of uncertainty

A conversation becomes tough when we can't see what's happening. In particular, we find it impossible to read the other person's intentions. As a result, we make assumptions about those intentions – and those assumptions tend to take a predictable form. All too often, we allocate blame.

Blame is, in fact, a completely natural and understandable reaction to uncertainty. Faced with a situation that we don't understand, we will tend to assume that it's been created by someone – or something – *deliberately*. We might blame the gods for natural catastrophes; we construct conspiracy theories to explain

extraordinary tragedies. We blame, even when there's no one obvious to blame: we shout at the computer when it crashes, we kick a burst tyre. In a conversation, blame is a natural response to behaviour we can't read clearly.

Top tip

If you find yourself blaming someone, try one or more of these tactics. Stop generalizing. What makes this situation different? Resist the temptation to make life difficult for the person. Separate the problem from the person. Talk to them about it.

As well as finding it impossible to read the other person's intentions, we find it hard to read their reactions to what we are saying. Mostly, we can exercise what psychologists call a theory of mind: we can infer the other person's thoughts and feelings by reading their behaviour. In a tough conversation, the readings we pick up from their gestures, facial expressions and verbal responses fail to add up: they're confusing or contradictory. Something is not quite right, but we can't work out what it is.

Emotional arousal

Faced with these uncertainties, our minds tend to respond emotionally.

Think of your brain as being like an office building with three floors. (This explanation of brain function – it's called the *triune brain* – is grossly simplified but nonetheless helpful.) In the basement (usually called the brain stem) are the control systems for the body's vital functions: heart rate, breathing, body temperature, balance and so on. On the ground floor – it's actually in the centre of the brain – is the limbic system, which acts as a kind of reception area for all the information that enters the brain. Sitting at the front desk in the limbic system is the amygdala, which we can

think of as a kind of security officer. The amygdala has a very simple job: it gives incoming information a visitor's badge, in the form of an emotional tag. If the visitor is welcome, the amygdala sends it up to the top floor of the brain, the neocortex, which can think more subtly and intelligently about the information.

But if the amygdala decides that the information is unwelcome, it will tag it as dangerous. It's like a security alert. And the first thing that happens in a security alert, of course, is that the lifts are closed down. No more shuttling between floors; no more subtle, intelligent thinking. The limbic system cuts off all neural connections to the neocortex and calls in the emotions to deal with the threat. We call this *emotional arousal*: in the words of Daniel Goleman, author of *Emotional Intelligence*, the limbic system hijacks the neocortex. It's a survival mechanism, helping us to deal with a situation *without thinking about it*.

The problem, of course, is that this emotional arousal only serves to make a tough conversation tougher. The emotions – the fear, anger or embarrassment – are telling us to act: to do something *now*, without stopping to think. The limbic system has reduced our options to just two: run away, or fight it out. Hence the name: the *fight-or-flight response*.

The combat mentality

If one person in a conversation is experiencing the fight-or-flight response, the conversation is likely to become difficult. The other person may have to use all their skill to reduce their emotional arousal and cancel the security alert in their brain. But all too often, faced with aggressive behaviour, our own limbic systems respond to the threat – and what Holly Weeks calls the combat mentality is established. A difficult conversation has become tough.

The combat mentality treats the conversation as a battle. Every move is seen as an unprovoked attack, and the only strategy available to our brains – locked down in that limbic security alert – is to defend or attack. The combat mentality can cause real damage:

bruising emotional wounds that can leave permanent scars on a working relationship.

How we make tough conversations tougher

These three elements – uncertainty, emotional arousal, the combat mentality – act together. Between them, they create a self-reinforcing, vicious cycle. As it spirals out of control, we feel increasingly powerless to intervene. We may want to save the conversation; we may even be able to see what's going wrong. But we can't think about what to do. Instead, the cycle dictates our behaviour.

First, as we've seen, we blame the other person for the problem. And in blaming them, we assume ourselves to be innocent. That assumption of innocence can become what Holly Weeks calls 'the delusion of good intentions': the idea that tough conversations shouldn't happen to us, because we mean well and we always try to do our best. It's a delusion because it doesn't take account of how we might be contributing to the other person's behaviour. As a result, we evade responsibility for the conversation. We justify what we do as the inevitable result of what *they* are doing, and *only* what they are doing.

Second, emotional arousal leads us to oversimplify the problem. Simplifying our thinking is one of the prime functions of emotions: they make it easier for us to choose what to do. In fact, we *don't* choose what to do; the emotion chooses for us.

Our resulting strategies respond to the oversimplified problem by forcing an oversimplified solution. The emotions force us into black-and-white thinking: this or that, good or bad. We might try to force through an either/or decision: yes or no, your way or my way, take it or leave it. Or we might go for the generalizing strategy: this is always what happens when we discuss this issue, it's always bad, and this is what we always do to deal with it.

And third, the combat mentality dictates a whole host of strategies. Battles have only two outcomes: win or lose. Once we've taken on the combat mentality, every move must aim to win. For example, we might notice the other person engaging in what Holly Weeks calls 'thwarting ploys'. The aim of these ploys, she writes, 'is to get us to back off, to make our counterparts themselves come out on top, or to get out of the conversation altogether'.

Thwarting ploys come in all shapes and sizes. Some are defensive, some offensive; some manage to be both. They might include:

- bursting into tears;
- laughing off a derogatory remark as a joke;
- pleading external duties that make it impossible to stop and talk;
- switching the topic of conversation unexpectedly.

The most successful thwarting ploys have one feature in common: they're hard to read. We have come full circle, back to that first key feature of tough conversations: the fog of uncertainty. Thwarting ploys add to the uncertainty; that's why we use them. What's worse, when we spot a thwarting ploy, we often assume that we know why the other person is using it. But of course, we might be wrong. Is the other person wilfully, or genuinely, misunderstanding what we say? Are they evading the issue or simply changing the subject? Are they upset or putting it on?

Three steps towards better tough conversations

How can we break this cycle? Given the complexity of tough conversations – the fog of uncertainty, the swirl of emotion, the smoke of combat – can we find tactics that are simple enough to remember and practise?

Holly Weeks suggests that our strategy should begin with three-way respect. We should respect ourselves, the other person and the conversation itself.

Self-respect, to begin with, means paying attention to our own needs.

What humans need

We all have needs that we must meet in order to function as effective human beings. Some needs are physical; others are psychological.

Physical Needs	Psychological Needs
Air	Security
Water	Attention
Nutritious food	A sense of autonomy and control
Sleep	Emotional connections to others
Sensory stimulation	Membership of a community
Physical exercise	Friendship, fun, love, intimacy
Shelter	Sense of status in social situations
Safety	Sense of competence and achievement
	Meaning and purpose:
	— people who need us
	— activities that stretch us (flow; peak experiences that focus our attention; being 'in the zone')
	— connection to a bigger picture

A conversation can become tough if one of us feels that something in the conversation threatens a need. If you sense resistance – either in yourself or in the other person – ask yourself, 'What need is being threatened here?'

This model of human needs is based on the Human Givens approach, pioneered by Joe Griffin and Ivan Tyrrell.

Self-respect means meeting our needs. Among the most important of those needs are:

- Competence: the sense that we're good at what we do.
- Autonomy: the sense that we're in control of our lives.
- Relatedness: the sense that we're connected to others.

(The mnemonic 'CAR' will help you to remember these three core needs.) Meeting our needs doesn't mean ignoring the needs of others. Neither does it mean using thwarting ploys to protect our need. A ploy is likely to protect us only in the short term; self-respect means knowing that we need to meet our needs more fully and deeply.

Respect for the other person means acknowledging that they, too, have the same needs that we have. Respecting them doesn't mean that we must agree with them or give way to them. Neither does it mean that we should like them. It means simply that we should recognize that they have needs and interests of their own.

Of course, part of what they're doing is responding to what *we* are saying and doing. It may be extremely important to them, for example, not to lose face: not to be embarrassed or humiliated publicly. So respecting the other person also means seeking to understand how our behaviour might be affecting their self-esteem. (*What effect am I having?*) This means understanding our own behaviour more deeply. Thus, respect for ourselves and for the other person reinforce each other.

Finally, respecting the conversation means recognizing it for what it is: tough. Holly Weeks suggests that we view a tough conversation as a landscape to be navigated. 'Rather than put our heads down and start to plough through,' she writes, 'we will do better to step back, take a satellite view and think about the lay of the land.' We're looking for an effective route through the obstacles that this conversation is likely to throw up.

How does this three-way respect play out in practice? What can we *do*?

We could start by considering the context of the conversation. Do you need to act on either of these questions?

- *Time*. Is this the right time? What is the history behind the conversation?
- *Place*. Are you somewhere comfortable, quiet, and – perhaps above all – private?

If you pick the right time and the right place, the conversation has a better chance of turning out better. And there are other tactics we could choose to try.

But we do need to *choose* what to do. A tough conversation is unlikely to improve by chance. The three elements – the fog of uncertainty, emotional arousal and the combat mentality – act as a mutually reinforcing cycle. We can start anywhere in the cycle. But we need to start somewhere. And only *we* can choose to act. We can't predict what the other person does, and we may not be able to control their behaviour directly. But we can influence their behaviour by what we do. It's up to us.

Clearing the fog of uncertainty

If we want to reduce uncertainty in a tough conversation, we need more information. We need to use all the skills of enquiry that we can muster.

A good first step is to banish blame. As we have seen, blame encourages us to believe that the other person's intentions are hostile towards us. If we simply reverse this assumption, we open up new possibilities for gaining information.

The principle is: *assume constructive intent*. (We've mentioned this tactic before, at the end of Chapter 4.) Assume that the other person is doing what they're doing, and saying what they're saying, for good reasons: reasons that make sense to them. They are trying to meet their needs for competence, autonomy or relatedness, in some way. Assume, also, that they may not *know* precisely why they're doing what they're doing.

It is possible, even in the threatening confusion of a tough conversation, to make this very simple move. But assuming constructive intent will be easier if you've practised the skill beforehand.

Exercise

Assuming constructive intent

Try this whenever you are relaxed and able to observe someone's behaviour without feeling threatened by it. (Meetings are good opportunities to do this exercise. You might be observing two people discussing an issue, without participating directly yourself.) The moment to watch for is when someone disagrees with a remark or seems to show resistance. Ask yourself the question: 'What good reason might they have for resisting or disagreeing?' Test your thinking using the three needs we have mentioned: competence, autonomy, relatedness. Is it possible that one of these needs is being threatened? How could you find out, if you were taking part in this conversation?

The next move is to ask questions. A really powerful information-gathering tool is the ladder of inference. Look back at Chapter 3: you'll find plenty of questions there that will help you to climb down the ladder of inference and explore the beliefs and facts underlying what the other person is saying.

We often go into conversations knowing that they will be difficult. In those cases, we can plan the questioning strategy to help us clear the fog of uncertainty. The trick is to have lots of questions ready, and be ready to change direction at any point. Plan, but don't script.

Reducing emotional arousal

That tangled thicket of emotions is probably the greatest obstacle in your path through a tough conversation. Although we're looking

at emotions as the second element of tough conversations, you may need to tackle emotional arousal first, before you can make any more progress.

Why can emotions be so disabling? Because they stop us thinking clearly. That's their natural function (and this bears repeating): emotions tell us how to act *without thinking*. (Look back at the notes on *pathos* in Chapter 5. E-motions provoke *motion*.) Tough conversations, more than any others, need us to think clearly. Extreme, negative emotions get in the way of clear thinking.

How can we reduce emotional arousal? Work on yourself before trying to influence the other person. The first step is to focus on your breathing. Take a couple of deep breaths and try to breathe *out* for longer than you breathe *in*. This technique is called *7/11 breathing*.

Top tip

You can find an exercise to help you do 7/11 breathing in Chapter 7.

You should have plenty of time to work on your breathing while listening to the other person answering your questions; if you can't seem to find the space to breathe for a moment, you may be talking too much!

Now slow the conversation down. Review the material in Chapter 3 on managing time. A very effective way to slow the pace of the conversation is to work on your voice: lower the volume, lower the pitch and lower the pace. The effect on the other person can be magical: it's very hard to counter the effect of a soothing voice. But you must practise the technique so that you can engage it when you need to; the emotion of a tough conversation will be working hard against you.

You can alter your breathing and your voice in a matter of seconds. Now focus on the words of the conversation. If you repeat

and paraphrase what the other person has been saying, you will discharge some of the emotion.

For example, if the other person says ‘The sales targets are just too high’, you could paraphrase by saying: ‘So let me get this right. Are you saying that the sales targets have been set too high?’ The paraphrase – especially if posed as a question – gives the other person the opportunity to reflect on their thinking, develop it or examine it. Paraphrasing can help both of you to think more objectively about the problem.

Paraphrasing can also slow down a conversation and instil a little calm – a tough conversation is unlikely to become relaxed, but at least you’ll now have the chance to navigate it more successfully.

From conflict to collaboration

Collaboration means working together to navigate the landscape of the conversation. One way to do that is to take a ‘satellite view’ of the conversation’s subject.

Try running a ‘how to’ exercise. The technique is almost ridiculously simple: we define the problem as a phrase beginning with the words ‘how to’. Invite the other person to join you in creating a ‘how to’ statement that defines the problem you are discussing. Offer your own ‘how to’ if you wish, and spend some time generating new, alternative ‘how to’ statements: different ways of defining the problem, different views of the problem, parts of the problem. Questions that will help you to generate more ‘how to’ statements include:

- What are we trying to achieve here?
- What do you want to do?
- If we could do this, what other problem would that solve?
- What do we need to do in order to do this?

Top tip

Writing down the ‘how to’ statements will help you to objectify the problem still further. Sticky notes are useful: write each ‘how to’ on a separate note and start clustering them. By visualizing the problem in this way, you give yourself a greater opportunity to collaborate on solving it.

‘How to’ is a powerful first-stage thinking technique. (Look back at the section on structuring your thinking in Chapter 3.) It works particularly well as part of the second conversation in the sequence of four that we explored in Chapter 3: the conversation for possibility.

Edward de Bono, as we have seen in Chapter 3, calls conflict ‘adversarial thinking’. According to de Bono, there are four main types of adversarial thinking.

- Critical thinking: looking for what is wrong with an idea.
- Ego thinking: identifying ourselves with our idea, so that attacking the idea becomes a personal attack.
- Political thinking: using ideas to create allies or destroy alliances.
- Rigid thinking: simplifying and reducing complexity so that ideas become impossible to develop or change.

You may be able to detect one or more of these types of thinking in the tough conversation you’re holding. If so, these questions may help to defuse conflict and increase the chances of collaboration.

- To counter critical thinking, ask: ‘What is good about this idea?’
- To counter ego thinking, ask: ‘When does this happen? In what circumstances does this idea *not* apply?’
- To counter political thinking, ask: ‘What are the strengths and weaknesses of this idea?’

- To counter rigid thinking, ask: ‘What if...? What if... happened? What if... were not happening? What if... you could solve this problem?’

Tough conversations demand more than good intentions. They demand clear thinking, a clear strategy and clear tactics. Navigating a tough conversation doesn’t mean ignoring the needs of the other person, but neither does it mean giving way or running away. We may not be able to understand or influence the other person’s behaviour in a tough conversation – that’s part of what makes it tough – but we can alter our own behaviour. The techniques we’ve explored in this chapter help us to improve the prospects for a tough conversation by acting on our side.

These techniques have one thing in common. We need to practise them before we need to use them. We can try out most of them in relaxed conversations. Once we understand how they can help us, we will be ready whenever a conversation becomes tough.

Summary points

- Tough conversations have three key features:
 - the fog of uncertainty, particularly in reading the other person’s intentions;
 - emotional arousal;
 - a combat mentality.
- We can make tough conversations tougher by making poor tactical choices:
 - The fog of uncertainty encourages us to blame the other person for the problem, and creates a delusion of good intentions.
 - Emotional arousal causes us to oversimplify the problem and seek oversimplified solutions: forced either/or decisions, or generalized judgements.

- The combat mentality provokes many strategies, including thwarting ploys.
- We can only manage tough conversations better if we respect ourselves, the other person and the conversation itself:
 - Self-respect means understanding our own needs and working to meet them.
 - Respecting the other person means remembering their needs and that they are trying to meet them.
 - Respecting the conversation means thinking about it as a landscape to be navigated together.
- We can adopt a number of techniques to break the cycle of a tough conversation:
 - We can clear the fog of uncertainty by assuming constructive intent, asking questions and using the ladder of inference.
 - We can reduce emotional arousal by working on our breathing and our voice, and by paraphrasing the other person's remarks before responding to them.
 - We can transform combat into collaboration by using the 'how to' technique, and by responding carefully to the four forms of adversarial thinking: critical thinking, ego thinking, political thinking and rigid thinking.
- Tough conversations demand more than good intentions. They demand clear thinking, a clear strategy and clear tactics. We need to practise these techniques before finding ourselves in a tough conversation.

07

Making a presentation

Think of a presentation as a formal conversation. It's a largely one-way conversation with a few specific rules: you are speaking, and the audience is supposed to be listening. You're leading; they are following. It's not the most natural of conversations. And that is where the challenges begin.

Top tip

In this chapter, I use the word 'presentation' to mean your performance in front of an audience. Many people now use the word to refer to a slide deck – indeed, for many people, the slides *are* the presentation. There are notes on producing slides later in this chapter, but your presentation is *not* the slides. The presentation is *you*, engaging your audience's attention.

A recent study in the United States asked people about their deepest fears. Intriguingly, death came in at number seven. At the top of the list – above deep water, financial problems, insects and heights – was speaking to groups.

Why the anxiety? I think it's because, when we present, we put ourselves on show. The audience will be judging not just our ideas, but *us*. People may not easily remember reports or spreadsheets; but they will certainly remember a presenter who looks nervous or incompetent.

That nervous, jittery feeling is caused by adrenalin, a hormone secreted by your adrenal glands (near your kidneys). Adrenalin constricts your arteries, increasing your blood pressure and stimulating the heart. Why stimulate the heart? To give you extra energy. And when do you need extra energy? When you're in danger.

Adrenalin release is an evolved response to threat. It's all part of the fight-or-flight response, which helps us to confront or run away from life-threatening situations. Symptoms include a rapid pulse (to keep the blood well oxygenated), dilated pupils (so that we can see better) and sweaty palms (to help us grip a weapon).

That adrenalin rush has two other effects. It increases your concentration – particularly useful when making a presentation. Less usefully, adrenalin also stimulates excretion of body waste. This decreases your body weight, helping you to run faster. And *that* is why you want to visit the toilet immediately before presenting.

But the worst of it is that the audience will forget virtually everything you say.

That's the bad news.

The good news is that nervousness can help you to present more effectively. It's telling you that this presentation matters – and that *you* matter. An effective presenter puts themselves centre-stage; so you have every right to feel nervous. In fact, you *should* feel nervous. Your task is to *manage* those nerves.

Exercise

The best way to deal with nerves is to work on your breathing. Find somewhere comfortable to sit and relax. Relax your shoulders and put your hands on your stomach. Breathe in and out, if you can, through your nose: breathe in for a count of seven and out for a count of eleven. If these counts are too high, start with lower numbers – 3/6 perhaps – and work up towards 7/11. The important thing is to breathe *out* for longer than you breathe

in. Check your shoulders: they should be remaining still. Check your hands: they should be gently pushing your stomach *out* as you breathe in, and falling back into your stomach as you breathe out. It may help to close your eyes and concentrate on counting as you do this exercise. (Combine this with the exercise on using your voice in Chapter 5.)

Breathing in and out at a count of 7/11 is brilliant for calming nerves and reducing anxiety. Breathing in quickens the heartbeat and stimulates adrenalin production; breathing out does the opposite, slowing the heart and the production of adrenalin. We tend to breathe in too much when we are anxious; 7/11 breathing simply reverses the connection, so that our breathing makes us less anxious. Practising 7/11 breathing also helps us to worry less, by forcing us to concentrate simply on our breathing.

Preparing for the presentation

Those nerves also reflect the uncertainty of a live presentation. The Greeks called this element *kairos*, a word that translates roughly as ‘the opportune moment’.

The effective presenter understands that their presentation will be affected by a host of uncontrollable factors. You can’t plan for the audience’s mood. You may not even be able to foresee who will be there. You can’t plan for any sudden external development that might affect your topic. You can’t plan for every question that you might be asked.

But that, of course, is also the greatest strength of a presentation. You and the audience are together, in the same place, at the same time. This is a unique moment. You can respond to the *kairos*, if, as the Greeks did, you see it as an opportunity.

Exercise

What will affect the *kairos* the next time you make a presentation? Spend a little time thinking about the specific circumstances you will be working with: the audience's mood, what has been happening to them recently, events in the outside world that will be on their minds. How can you adapt your presentation to acknowledge or address those factors?

If you can support your nerves with solid preparation, you can channel your nervous energy into the performance itself. Prepare in three areas:

- the material;
- the audience;
- yourself.

Managing the material

Your most important task is to hold the audience's attention.

Presentations fail for many reasons. Perhaps the most common problem is that the presenter talks *about* something, rather than talking *to the audience*.

Other presentations fail because the presenter organizes the material as if it's a document. A presentation is not a report – or a set of slides. It needs to be structured like a *performance*: a story, a comedy routine, a piece of music. That performing structure must take the audience on a journey, with lots of interesting twists and turns along the way to hold their attention.

Defining your objective

Why are you presenting? What do you want your audience to *do* at the end? Your objective must be to say whatever is necessary to persuade them to take that action.

In other words, presentations are ideal for *influencing* and *persuading* an audience. On the whole, a presentation is not a good medium for *explaining* something. It's worth repeating this point: your audience is probably going to forget almost everything you say. So packing your presentation full of information – on slides, or anywhere else – is almost certainly counterproductive. If your brief is to explain something, try to find some persuasive element that will inject passion and purpose into the presentation. And if you *must* offer your audience detailed information, put it in supporting notes.

I believe that there's only one reason why you should be making a presentation. It may sound rather grand, but a presentation should *inspire* your audience. They want to be moved, involved, intrigued. Above all, they want to feel that they can *identify* with you and your ideas. They also want to identify with each other: that they are, for the brief time that this presentation lasts, a single community. Your task is to create in your audience that multiple sense of identification – with you, with your ideas and with themselves – so that they'll be inspired to act.

Write down your objective in one sentence. This helps you to:

- clear your mind;
- select material to fit;
- check at the end of planning that you are still addressing a single clear issue.

Write a simple sentence beginning:

'The aim of this presentation is to...'

Make sure the verb following that word 'to' is suitably inspirational!

Analysing your audience

Your presentation will be successful if the audience feels that you have spoken directly to them. If your ideas directly address their needs, they will pay much more attention to them. Remember the skills of *ethos*, which we explored in Chapter 5? If you can show that you share the audience's values, that you value practical common sense and the middle way, and that you have made a personal investment in your ideas, your audience will respect you. And if they respect you, they'll be more inclined to believe you.

So think about your audience carefully.

- How many will there be?
- What is their status range?
- Will they want to be there?
- How much do they already know about the matter? How much more do they need to know?
- How does your message and your material relate to the audience?
- Is the audience young or old? Are they predominantly one gender or mixed?

Your audience has certain expectations – of you and of itself. They will expect you to be competent, to set the pace and direction of the presentation, and to stay in control. They will expect themselves to be led, to be told what to think and feel, and to respond as a single group. Audiences can respond actively in presentations in only a few ways. They can interrupt you – to ask a question, to contradict you or to heckle you; they can laugh; and they can applaud. Your audience will expect you to manage these responses.

Constructing a message

Once you have your objective, and some sense of who your audience is, you can plan your material.

Work out your message. Look back at our notes on messages in Chapter 5. Your presentation's message must:

- be a sentence;
- express your objective;
- contain a single idea;
- have no more than 15 words;
- grab your audience's attention.

Make your message as vivid as you can. An effective message – in a presentation, we can call it the 'take-home message' – sticks in the mind long after the presentation is over.

Top tip

The subject of your presentation matters far less than your message. People giving ordinary presentations *talk about* something: that's the subject. Brilliant presenters *say* something to their audience: that's the message, Focus, always, on your message.

Creating a structure

Everything in the structure of the presentation should revolve around your message.

You could use Aristotle's three modes of appeal as a structuring device (we looked at these at the start of Chapter 5).

- Start with *ethos*: establish your credentials for speaking to this audience.
- Continue with *logos*: deliver your message and a small number of supporting points (three is always a good number to aim for).
- And end with *pathos*: a rousing call to action that appeals to your audience's emotions.

If you have only a short time to plan your presentation, this three-part structure will serve you well.

Monroe's motivated sequence

In the 1930s, Alan Monroe, a psychology professor at Purdue University in Indiana, invented a model that develops the three-part structure into a five-step sequence. Monroe suggested that, 'when confronted with a problem, people look for a solution; when they feel a want or need, they search for a way to satisfy it'. (These needs are the self-same needs that we looked at in Chapter 6.) Monroe's motivated sequence structures a presentation to exploit this desire to satisfy needs.

At step one, capture the audience's attention. Ask a question, tell a story or use a quotation. Above all, say or do something *surprising*. At this point, the audience should be asking itself: 'Where is this presentation going? What's going to happen?'

At step two, convince the audience that they're confronting a problem. They may already know about this problem; showing that you understand it will increase your *ethos* with them. Or you might present them with a new, shocking problem. Create dissatisfaction and discomfort, and the need for resolution. At this point, the audience should be saying to itself: 'This is serious. What can we do?'

At step three, introduce your solution. How will it solve the problem? This is the heart of your presentation: it's where *logos* comes to the fore. Build a pyramid (we looked at pyramids in Chapter 5). Drive home your key message and lay out a small number of key points to support it. Summarize your ideas as you go, so that the audience never gets lost. At this point, they should be saying: 'This seems to be the obvious solution. But how will it work in practice? And how will it affect me?'

At step four, visualize the future. Describe how the world will look if the audience does nothing. Or describe a world in which

your solution has been implemented. Or do both. At this point, the audience should be almost audibly crying out: 'Tell us what to do!'

Finally, at step five, make your call to action. Make the action simple and, if possible, immediate. And don't forget the *pathos*: we act on our emotions, so stir the audience with the emotion that's appropriate to the action you want them to take.

Monroe's motivated sequence has served presenters well for almost 90 years. It's adaptable to many different themes. Above all, it helps us to plan material that speaks directly to our audience.

Putting it on cards

The very best presenters work without notes. They speak with effortless ease, apparently improvising a seamless thread of glittering eloquence.

Don't be fooled. That spontaneity has been carefully planned and rehearsed. It represents an ideal that we could all aim for, but there's no shame in not quite achieving it. On the way to speaking without notes, you could consider writing the full text of your presentation, reading from an autocue (which displays the text you speak on a semi-transparent screen), or putting prompt notes onto cards. All three methods have advantages and challenges.

A script gives you complete control. You need never stumble over your words again! Using a script, you can choose your words carefully and you'll never overrun: you can time your presentation to the second. On the other hand, you may not be very competent at reading a script; the words may remain obstinately on the page and refuse to leap into life.

An autocue releases you from the burden of looking down to read your script. You can look up and around, while actually reading your script. And that might help to energize your delivery.

Most presenters probably choose the option of notes on cards. Filing or archive cards are best; use the largest you can find. Cards have a number of key advantages.

- They are less shaky than paper – they don't rustle.
- They are more compact.
- They give your hands something firm to hold.
- They look more professional.
- They force you to write only brief notes.

By writing only brief notes, triggers and cues on your cards, you force yourself to think about what you are saying, while you are saying it. As a result, you'll sound more convincing.

The challenge of using cards is that you'll have to think about what to say. Those 'ums' and 'ers' may reappear; you may find yourself using irritating mannerisms or meaningless phrases (some presenters don't even notice that they're using them until they are told by a kind colleague). To overcome these glitches in delivery, try to cultivate deliberate silence while you're working out what to say.

Write your notes in bold print, using pen or felt-tip. Write on only one side and number the cards sequentially. Include:

- what you *must* say;
- what you *should* say to support the main idea;
- what you *could* say if you have time.

Keep the cards simple to look at and rehearse with them so that you get to know them. And don't forget to hold them together with a treasury tag!

Exercise

The next time you're preparing a presentation, find time to draw a picture of it. Put all your notes away; you are working from

memory here. Find as large a piece of paper as possible, and pens or pencils of different colours, and draw the presentation as a journey, or perhaps a storyboard (like a strip cartoon, the kind of drawings that film-makers use to map out a sequence of shots). You're aiming for a single route through the material. Put memorable stopping places along the way: signposts, buildings, statues, posters, etc. Now use your drawing to help you rehearse.

PRAISE: Adding spice

Exciting presentations bring ideas alive. There's a famous story about a little girl who claimed she liked plays on the radio, 'because the pictures were better'. Pictures on slides can be good; but *these* pictures – the ones you create in your audience's minds with your words – are often better.

Here are six ways in which you can stimulate your audience's imagination. We can remember them using the mnemonic PRAISE.

- *Proverbs* state ideas in memorable form. Make your message or your key points sound like advertising jingles or political slogans. Your audience will leave the presentation quoting them with delight.
- *Resonators* bring ideas to life by attaching them to vivid images. These images contain lots of sensory information: appeals to sight, sound, touch, taste, smell or feeling. They work especially well if they involve human beings doing things. Find concrete examples that illustrate your ideas.
- *Attention-grabbers* do just that: they capture or recapture your audience's attention. Surprise and suspense work well as attention-grabbers. So do figures of speech: turns of phrase or unusual ways of using language that make ideas stand out memorably. Among the most common figures of speech are metaphor, antithesis (contrast), rhetorical questions and three-part lists.

- *Influencers* give your ideas the weight of authority. You might deliver that authority in your job title, your experience or your behaviour. Information gains authority if you point out the authority of its source or author. Presenters often try to give their ideas greater influence by quoting famous authors.
- *Stories*, as we've already seen, can be more persuasive than the most authoritative statistics. We believe stories, however fantastical: we identify with the characters and we face their challenges with them. The story of one person can often be more convincing than a mass of carefully documented evidence.
- *Emotions*, as we have already seen, influence us more strongly than reasoned argument. We act on our emotions. Colour your argument with emotion and it will touch parts of the brain that logic cannot reach.

Exercise

Take a Big Idea that you will be arguing for in the near future. On a piece of paper, write down some ideas for examples of each of these PRAISE techniques: proverbial expressions, resonating examples, attention-grabbers, sources of influence, stories and emotional elements.

Designing visuals

'Death by PowerPoint': it's a worryingly familiar phrase. Too many business audiences are now suffering from PowerPoint fatigue. And the overwhelming reason for this fatigue is that presenters are not using slides properly.

Put simply: presenters should be putting *pictures* on slides, not text.

Slides are *visual*. They should offer information that can't be put into words. Why show a visual otherwise? This point is so blazingly obvious that it seems amazing, at first, how many presenters ignore it. But if we look at the way that slide programs have been promoted, the reason for this problem becomes clearer.

Computer slides have been sold to us as a way of making life easier for presenters. We've been told that slides make us look more prepared and – allegedly – professional. We've been told that slides can act as notes, with the audience being offered hard copy after the presentation.

We've been seduced, in other words, into putting *text* onto slides, rather than pictures.

In fact, computer-generated slides are the descendants, not of the earlier 35mm slide, but of a much older technology: the blackboard. But – unlike the blackboard – slides display text *before* the speaker speaks it, rather than *while* they speak. The audience is forced to read and listen at the same time – usually, to different text – and they do neither very well (a troubling effect that psychologists call 'cognitive dissonance'). What's more, by flashing a piece of text onto a screen in advance of talking about it, the presenter completely destroys any element of surprise or anticipation.

What's worse still, slides seduce presenters into presenting *less well*. They feel forced to 'speak to the slides' (which many do, literally), thus breaking their link with the audience. The presenter is no longer presenting: they have become a voiceover. Result: the audience loses concentration. (Think of what schoolchildren often do when their teacher turns away from them and writes on the blackboard.) Because they are not writing and speaking – as they would with a blackboard – presenters can't decide exactly what to say: should they read out what's on the slide (which is probably too brief and vague to make sense anyway), or paraphrase it (thus increasing the cognitive dissonance for the audience)?

Of course, slides can be effective. But they should *support* your presentation, not substitute for it.

- Remove words. Unless you want to discuss a piece of text, it should not appear on a slide.
- Use pictures. Photos, maps, diagrams – any kind of graphic will do as long as it's *simple*.
- Create *visual dissonance*. An image on a slide should show less than the audience needs to understand it; you, the presenter, can then resolve the tension by talking about it.

If you *must* put words on slides, make them big enough for the audience to read, and put no more words on the slide than you would expect the audience to read.

Better still: turn off the projector and concentrate on presenting.

Rehearsing

Rehearsal is the reality check. I am astonished at how many presenters think they can simply turn up and run a presentation without rehearsing it. The truth is: you cannot rehearse too much. Rehearsal helps you to remember what you want to say; it helps you to get the timing right; and it helps you to master nerves.

Rehearse success. We so often rehearse failure: we imagine what will go wrong, over and over again. Instead, when you run through your presentation, imagine precisely what you'll do and say – and imagine doing it brilliantly. Imagine speaking confidently and eloquently; imagine the audience listening attentively to your every word and applauding warmly when you have finished. (There is an exercise in Chapter 9 to help you rehearse success.)

Rehearse in real time; don't skip bits. Rehearse with a colleague or friend. And rehearse, if you can, at least once in the venue where you'll be presenting.

Rehearsal gives you the freedom to perform when it's time to perform. Once you've rehearsed your material, you'll be better prepared to concentrate on what you should be doing in the presentation itself: talking to the audience.

Top tip

How long should your presentation be? The simple answer is: shorter than you think. Whether you've been told to speak for a certain length of time or not, aim to speak for no more than 20 minutes without a break of some kind. Remember: very few audiences ever wished that a presentation had been longer.

Controlling the audience

Your relationship with the audience matters much, much more than what you say. They will forget most of what you say. But they will remember *you*.

You are performing. Your whole body is involved. You must become aware of what your body is doing so that you can control it, and thus the audience.

Eye contact

As we said in Chapter 5, we speak more with our eyes than with our voices. Your eyes tell the audience that you're taking notice of them, that you know what you are saying and that you *believe* what you are saying.

Use your eyes to control the audience by keeping them under surveillance. Imagine a lighthouse beam shooting out from your eyes and scanning the audience. Make sure that the beam enters every pair of eyes in the room. Focus for a few seconds on each pair of eyes and meet their gaze.

Your face

The rest of your face is important, too! Remember to smile. Animate your face and remember to make everything just a little

larger than life so that your face can be ‘read’ at the back of the room.

Gestures

Find the gestures that are natural for you. If you’re a great gesticulator, don’t try to force your hands into rigid stillness. If you don’t normally gesture a great deal, don’t force yourself into balletic movements. Keep your gestures open, away from your body and into the room. Don’t cross your hands behind your back, and don’t put them in your pockets too much. (It’s a good idea to empty your pockets before the presentation so that you don’t find yourself jingling coins or keys.)

Movement

Aim for stillness. This does not mean that you should stand completely still all the time. Moving about the room shows that you’re making the space your own. But rhythmic, repetitive movement can be annoying and suggest the neurotic pacing of a panther in a cage. Try not to rock on your feet or tie your legs in knots! Aim to have both feet on the ground as much as possible and slow down your movements.

Looking after yourself

And you’ll *still* be nervous as the moment of truth approaches. Remember that those nerves are there to help you. If you have prepared adequately, you should be ready to use your nerves to encounter the uncertainty of live performance.

On some occasions, it can be useful to meet the audience and chat with them before you start. This can break the ice and put you more at ease.

Prepare your voice. Along with work on your breathing (we have already discussed 7/11 breathing earlier in this chapter), pay attention to the muscles around your mouth that help you to articulate your words. Try some tongue-twisters or sing a favourite song. Chew the cud, and get your tongue and lips really working and warmed up.

Exercise

A very simple exercise to bring your mouth muscles to life is to stick your tongue as far out of your mouth as you can and then speak a part of your presentation, trying to make the consonants as clear as you can. You only need to do this for about 30 seconds to wake up your voice and make it clearer. You will, of course, look rather silly while doing this, so it's best to do the exercise in a private place!

Answering questions

Many presenters are as worried about the question session as about the presentation itself. A few guidelines can help to turn your question session from a trial into a triumph.

- *Decide when to take questions.* This will probably be at the end. But you might prefer to take questions during the presentation. This is more difficult to manage but can improve your relationship with the audience.
- *Anticipate the most likely questions.* These may be 'frequently asked questions' that you can easily foresee. Others may arise from the particular circumstances of the presentation.
- *Use a 'plant'.* Ask someone to be ready with a question to start off the session. At the end of a presentation, an audience might hesitate to break the atmosphere by asking the first question.

- *Answer concisely.* Force yourself to be brief.
- *Answer honestly.* You can withhold information, but don't lie. Someone in the audience will almost certainly see through you.
- *Take questions from the whole audience.* From all parts of the room and from different 'social areas'.
- *Answer the whole audience.* Don't let questions seduce you into private conversations. Make sure the audience has heard the question.
- *If you don't know, say so.* And promise what you'll do later to answer the question.

Summary points

- To make an effective presentation means taking control of:
 - the material;
 - the audience;
 - yourself.
- To prepare the material:
 - define your objective;
 - analyse your audience;
 - construct a message;
 - create a structure (Monroe's motivated sequence);
 - put it on cards;
 - add spice (PRAISE);
 - design visuals;
 - rehearse.

- To control the audience, work on:
 - eye contact;
 - facial expression;
 - gestures;
 - movement.
- To look after yourself, pay attention to:
 - breathing;
 - articulation;
 - a strategy of answering questions.

08

Putting it in writing

Writing well is challenging. It takes skill, creativity and a certain level of technical knowledge. But perhaps the greatest challenge is that our writing has to communicate without us.

Think back to our key communication question. *What effect am I having?* Answering that question might be hard in a conversation; but it's a whole lot harder if we're writing to someone. Our reader is judging us in our absence. The tone of our writing suggests the kind of person we are; and the reader may read a tone in our writing that we didn't intend. Added to that, in normal conversation our listener is unlikely to think much about any mistakes we make when we speak (we discussed this in Chapter 2); but in our writing, they may well notice errors of grammar, spelling or punctuation. And they'll judge us – at least in part – by those errors.

Writing itself is changing fast. We read less on paper and more on screen. Formal reports are increasingly complemented by relatively informal emails and the immediacy of texting, messaging and tweeting. And behind all these developments lies another trend, almost unnoticed – until we pick up a pen.

Most of the time, we're not actually writing – we're *printing*. In the workplace, very few of us now see anyone's handwriting. Printing creates another barrier between us and our readers. Paradoxically, at just the time when social media encourages us to think of writing as a form of conversation, printing makes our writing less personal. All these developments are changing the way

we read, which means that we have to think even more carefully about how to write well.

Let's start by considering the most common form of writing in the workplace.

The trouble with email

In the time that it takes you to read this sentence, 20 million emails have been written. We apparently spend over 11 hours a week reading and answering our emails. And we read at least 30 per cent of them on mobile devices.

It's hardly any wonder that so many emails are misunderstood. We could blame carelessness, or the sense of urgency that makes us write emails too quickly. But the medium itself also contributes to the problem. Email lacks what the psychologists call paralinguistic information: the information we glean from a speaker's facial expressions, gestures and tone of voice.

We assume that email is like a conversation. So we assume that we're using these non-verbal elements when we write – and that our reader can see and hear them. Professor Justin Kruger of New York University, and his colleagues, found that these assumptions have three consistent effects.

- First, we're significantly less clear in our emails than we are in real conversations.
- Second, we generally overestimate how clear our emails are.
- And third, we consistently overestimate how well we understand the emails we read.

Professor Kruger found that these misjudgements were especially serious when email writers tried to convey double meanings: irony, for example, or sarcasm.

Research by Professor Kristin Byron of Syracuse University takes these findings further. She found that we tend to read emails

as more emotionally negative than the writer intended. We're likely to interpret intended positive expressions as emotionally neutral, and neutral expressions as more emotionally negative. For example, a writer may think that they're making a simple comment, but the reader may interpret that comment as criticism. According to Professor Byron, we're even more likely to interpret emails negatively if we perceive the writer to be higher in status than us, older, or – interestingly – male.

What's going on here? I think that, in assuming unconsciously that we're holding a conversation, the text of the email – and, even more, the screen on which we read it – acts like a mask. Talking to someone wearing a mask feels intimidating; email, perhaps, generates a similar unconscious feeling of threat.

Avoiding misunderstandings

Four strategies may help us to reduce the possibility of misunderstanding. They all rely on making ourselves more visible to the reader, somehow, in our emails.

First, we could use 'display rules'. For example, senders increasingly add disclaimers to emails such as: 'Please excuse the shortness of this email, it is sent from my iPad.' In one organization, all emails apparently end with the words: 'This email may display a telegraphic style that gives the false impression of curtness or insensitivity.'

Second, we could use emotional cues. If we explain explicitly how we're feeling, our reader will be less likely to misinterpret what we write. Use phrases like 'this situation makes me feel...' or 'actually, right now, I feel... about this.' Emoticons also act as emotional cues; recent research suggests that we now read the symbol :-) with the part of the brain that interprets real facial expressions. However, some readers may see emoticons as less authentic than other emotional cues.

Top tip

The three most important emotional cues in email are:

- how long we take to answer an email;
- the length of our message; and
- how formally we express ourselves.

Think about how each of these might affect the way your email is received.

Third, we could use email etiquette. This is really no more than a version of the politeness that we use in real conversations; it simply requires a little more effort when we're writing.

- Avoid the elements that readers are most likely to misunderstand: ambiguity, irony, sarcasm, humour. You know how easily a humorous remark can go wrong in conversation; think how much more likely it is to create a problem when it's written down.
- Add in some kindness, thoughtfulness and good manners. At the very least, use salutations, sign-offs and 'handshakes': those little relationship-building remarks at the beginning and end of an email.
- Avoid CAPITAL LETTERS; they look as if you're shouting. Avoid underlining; it makes text harder to read. And avoid excessive use of italics or exclamation marks, which can make your email look too excitable.

Finally, we could pay attention to the one element that email often lacks: context. If the reader can't work out what this email is about, they'll be baffled. They can't ask you (unless they send yet another email); you need to help them. Include some framing information: past history, recent activity, the last conversation you held. Setting the scene may seem like waffling to you, but it will help your reader to tune in more quickly to what you're saying.

Building credit with your reader

Misunderstandings often arise when we email someone to ask them to do something. A simple request can be misinterpreted as a curt order; an instruction to change something can be read as criticism. How can we use email to persuade people to act, without causing offence?

Think of your relationship with your reader as being like a bank account. If you want to draw on that account, you'll probably need to put some funds in first. How can you add credit to your relationship with the reader? What can you offer them? Simply telling someone to do something can easily be interpreted as 'pushing' them; if you can find a way to 'pull' them towards the action you are seeking, you may get a more positive response. Thanking, praising, encouraging and helping all count as deposits in the bank account of your working relationship.

Try to think – and write – collaboratively. Mirroring can work well: using the reader's language suggests that you're thinking like them. But aligning can work even better: find the common cause, contribute something to it and *then* ask for help.

The writer Jay Heinrichs suggests thinking also about the tense you use in your emails. We use three tenses: past, present and future. Each carries hidden meanings, especially if we're asking our reader to do something.

- We associate the *past tense*, unconsciously, with blame or self-justification. Did this happen? Should it have happened? Who was responsible? Who should be punished?
- The *present tense* deals in values. It implicitly tells the reader what kind of person you are, and what values you hold.
- The *future tense* is about choice. It suggests decision making. The future tense leaps past blame and values, and seeks to do the right thing.

The tense to avoid, if possible, is the past. It can suggest blame, and it locks us into the past. You are looking for action *in the future*.

Focus on the present tense to bond with your reader, and on the future tense to create solutions.

From speaking to writing

Email is just one example of a general trend. The distinction between writing and speaking is becoming increasingly blurred. A formal style of writing increasingly sounds impersonal and distant; more and more, we expect written language to ‘sound’ more like speech. Hence the calls for plain English, for example, and the regular lampooning of ‘gobbledegook’ in the newspapers.

But reading is not like listening in a conversation. It takes more effort (and, of course, a certain level of education that listening does not require). Most of our readers – at work, at least – probably don’t *want* to read what we’ve written; they’re only reading because they *have* to.

So our task as writers is to make reading as easy as possible.

The reader contract

Your reader is making a contract with you. They’re willing to give your writing a certain level of attention for a certain length of time. A reader scrolling through their emails on their mobile device is not strongly committed to reading; their attention span is short, and your email is battling against a host of other information and distractions. A reader of a lengthy report, in contrast, will only begin to read if they’re relatively committed to reading it; they’re willing to give you more attention in the hope of a more substantial return. The reader contract, then, is somewhere on this spectrum between committed and uncommitted.

You need to respond to that contract. At the uncommitted end of the spectrum, your email must deliver your message as quickly as possible, and you must offer only information that’s directly relevant to your reader and your purpose. In your report, by

contrast, you can take more time; you can offer information that's more objective and more detailed.

The style spectrum

The style spectrum also responds to the reader contract. With uncommitted readers, your style needs to be immediate, simple, direct – closer, perhaps, to spoken language. With committed readers, your style can be more measured, less personal and more formal. More like writing, in fact.

Different kinds of writing tend to sit at different places on the style spectrum. Email sits at the informal end, along with leaflets, brochures, information sheets, magazine articles, blog posts and web pages. Reports sit at the formal end of the style spectrum, with minutes of meetings, proposals, research papers and academic essays.

However formal our style, we must always aim to be readable. Writing that's too informal will collapse into incoherence: sentences will ramble or remain incomplete; the writer might use idioms or slang that the reader finds incomprehensible or unacceptable. Very formal writing might include long, unfamiliar words and complicated sentences. It will convey no personality or warmth; it will be dry as dust.

We can choose where to place our writing on the formality spectrum. Neither end of the spectrum is superior to the other. The trick is to pick the style that works for our reader – and for the type of document we're writing.

Writing as you speak

People often tell me: 'I'm not a good writer. I write as I speak.' In fact, writing as you speak is perhaps one of the best ways to become a better writer.

The best way to write as you speak is to imagine speaking to your reader, and write down *exactly* what you would say to them. Doing this brings a number of benefits.

- You will naturally adapt your style to the reader you are speaking to.
- You will create more text than you need, which gives you plenty to edit.
- You will tend to get the grammar and punctuation right.

That last point sometimes surprises people. But in truth, most of us speak grammatically most of the time. And punctuation began as a set of marks indicating how to speak written words. So writing as you speak is a good first step towards a good piece of writing.

But it's not the last step.

Editing your work

The aim of editing is to make reading as easy as possible. Editing helps our writing to communicate without us: without the help of all that paralinguistic information in our voice, face and gestures. As well as making our draft clearer, editing also helps us to correct any errors.

Editing adapts our style on three levels. We can look at the words we use, the sentences we write and the paragraphs we construct.

Choosing words wisely

Four features mark out our words as formal or informal. We can think about:

- long words and short words;
- passive verbs and active verbs;
- abstract nouns;
- unnecessary words.

We can adjust each feature to adjust the style of our writing.

Long words or short words?

English has a huge vocabulary. It has grown out of many other languages: French, Latin and a host of languages from northern Europe. As a result, English often has two or three words meaning roughly (or *approximately*) the same thing. We can *try* or *endeavour*; we can *start*, *begin* or *commence* doing something; we can *anticipate* or *foresee*.

Which are the best words to choose? It depends where you want your writing to sit on the style spectrum. For historical reasons, long words in English are more formal than short ones. *I anticipate that the project will conclude successfully* is more formally expressed than *I expect the project to succeed*.

Many authorities on writing, especially those advocating plain English, tell us to choose short words rather than longer ones. This makes some sense: more people understand the word *chew* than the word *ruminate*, for example. But sometimes the longer word has a more exact meaning: *rumination*, in this example, is a particular *kind* of chewing. The long word may sometimes work better than the shorter one in technical writing, or if we're writing to a reader whose first language is not English. *Prefer* the short word to the long word; but don't assume that the shorter word is better.

Passive verbs or active verbs?

Verbs can be either active or passive. An active verb expresses what its subject does; a passive verb expresses what its subject suffers.

Sola wrote the report.

The report was written by Sola.

Sentences with passive verbs make your writing more formal, and active verbs more informal. In general, prefer active verbs to passive ones; but don't rule out passive verbs. They can help you to structure a sentence to emphasize a point differently; they can be useful when you don't know – or don't want to say – who did something. Passive verbs are not wrong; but active verbs bring your writing to life.

What do you mean, ‘abstract nouns’?

Nouns name things, people, times, places or qualities. *Concrete nouns* name things physically present in the world (*table, woman, pen, car, tree*); abstract nouns name ideas, concepts or qualities that cannot be sensed physically (*growth, awareness, training, marketing, possibility*).

Abstract nouns make your writing more formal. Many abstract nouns are longer words with standard endings: *-ion* (*translation, manipulation, specification*); *-ment* (*measurement, management, replacement*); *-ence* or *-ance* (*governance, maintenance, predominance*); or *-ity* (*acidity, functionality, superiority*).

To make your writing more formal, pile on the abstract nouns. If you want to make your writing less formal, replace abstract nouns with verbs or adjectives. If the only way to replace an abstract noun is to use a group of words, consider keeping it.

Which words do I need?

Some words contribute little to your meaning, but a lot to your tone. *We do these tests every week* says the same thing as *We perform these tests on a weekly basis*, but the second version undoubtedly sounds more professional and impressive. Using words – and adding words – to impress will make your writing more formal. If you remove them, your writing will ‘sound’ more direct, more ‘spoken’ – but also, perhaps, less polite. Generally, your writing will improve if it says more with fewer words:

The benefits of this arrangement are a saving in consultancy costs and the opportunity for new users to learn the system in a meaningful situation at the same time as they learn their jobs.

This arrangement saves consultancy costs and allows new users to learn the system as part of on-the-job learning.

Exercise

Pick an email that you wrote some time ago. Rewrite it, choosing to shift its style towards one or other end of the style spectrum.

Try to say exactly the same thing as in the original; try not to alter the meaning. What do you notice about the rewrites? How do you think the reader would react to your new version?

Constructing stunning sentences

Sentences express ideas. They will express your ideas better if you construct them well. Longer, more complicated sentences sound more formal; shorter, simpler sentences sound more informal. But this is not an iron rule: extremely informal writing might include very long, rambling sentences. Aim always to write as *clearly* as possible, however formal your style.

Follow the ‘15–25’ rule. Message sentences, topic sentences and other sentences expressing big ideas should never exceed 15 words. All other sentences should be no more than 25 words long.

Strengthen sentences by:

- cutting up long sentences into shorter, separate sentences;
- simplifying complicated sentences;
- finding strong subjects and verbs.

Put the subject as close to the start of the sentence as you can, and follow it as closely as possible with its verb. Try to choose subjects that act like characters in a story, and use the verb to say what the character is doing in the story. This sentence, for example, contains no characters: *The decision will be made on Friday*. The effect is very formal and distant. *The board will make its decision on Friday* introduces a character and the sense of a story. Of course, we could make the style of this sentence even more informal by removing the abstract noun: *The board will decide on Friday*.

Top tip

Put the new piece of information at the end of your sentence.
In that last example, we could write:

- 'The board will decide on Friday.'
- 'On Friday, the board will decide.'
- 'The decision will be made on Friday by the board.'

In each case, the meaning changes because a different element is emphasized at the end of the sentence. Sentences that don't end on a strong element will seem particularly rambling and weak.

Creating powerful paragraphs

Paragraphs indicate a certain level of formality. Reports, briefing papers and proposals always benefit from good paragraphing. Emails, in contrast, use paragraphs only sparingly. And the most informal writing – advertising, campaigning material, speeches – tends to be written more in single sentences than in paragraphs.

Paragraphs display the shape of your thinking. They show the individual main ideas and the relationships between them. Every time you make a new point, start a new paragraph.

Use a topic sentence at the start of each paragraph to summarize it. Topic sentences help you to decide what to include in each paragraph. You can think of a topic sentence as the paragraph's message. It should:

- be a fully grammatical sentence;
- make a single point;
- contain no more than 15 words;
- say something new.

Where can you find good topic sentences? You could write your paragraph first, then find the sentence that summarizes it. You could ask what you want to say in the paragraph, write down your topic sentence, and then construct your paragraph to support it. Often, you can find a topic sentence by looking at a paragraph's *last* sentence. Flip that concluding point to the top of the paragraph and see how well it works as a topic sentence.

Editing a paragraph

To minimize potential downtime and operational risk, it is recommended that the business case for the purchase of a back-up server, which could also be used for system testing, be formally examined. We are now addressing this since a decision is needed by the end of March to avoid additional hire costs or the loss of the rented machine.

Note how a topic sentence helps us to shorten this paragraph and make it more readable:

We are now examining the business case for buying a back-up server. This could:

- *minimize potential downtime;*
- *minimize operational risk;*
- *also be used for system testing.*

A decision is needed by the end of March to avoid extra hire costs or the loss of the rented machine.

Putting it all together: A strategy for editing

Editing helps us to say what we want to say more clearly. Whether we're aiming for a formal, more 'written' style, or a more informal style that's closer to speaking, we need to polish our writing so that it works as well as possible.

The most efficient strategy is to edit on these three levels, *in this order*:

- paragraphs;
- sentences;
- words.

Editing paragraphs will solve many problems at the sentence and word level, almost without our having to worry about them. And improving our sentence construction will automatically mean changing the words we use.

Add these top tips to make your editing strategy even more effective.

- Print it out. Your text looks different on paper: more immediate, less glassy. And it is sitting in your *hand*. You'll spot more errors than if you are staring at a screen.
- Take a break. Even if you're facing a tight deadline, walk away from your draft and come back to edit it. Even 30 seconds makes a difference. The longer the break, the better.
- Read it out loud. The best writing sounds elegant and eloquent. It makes its point with no fuss. Listen for the places where your writing jangles and grates.
- Pretend you are the intended audience. Is it possible that they will misinterpret what you have said, or – more importantly – the way you've said it? Check out ambiguous expressions, humour and complicated expressions.
- Use the readability statistics. You'll find them on your computer, if you're using Word. Look under the 'Review' tab at the 'Spelling and Grammar' dialogue boxes (or look up 'readability statistics' on your search engine.) These statistics are not subtle, but they do give you an objective measure of readability. And they can confirm that you're editing in the right direction.
- Be ruthless. The final step is to cut out whatever you don't need. Chop out words, sentences – even whole paragraphs, if you can. What remains will sparkle like a diamond.

Summary points

- Most of our writing in the workplace is likely to be email.
- We assume that email is like a conversation. As a result:
 - We are significantly less clear in our emails than we are in real conversations.
 - We generally overestimate how clear our emails are.
 - We consistently overestimate how well we understand the emails we read.
 - We tend to read emails as more emotionally negative than the writer intended.
- Four strategies may help us to reduce the possibility of misunderstanding:
 - Use ‘display rules’.
 - Use emotional cues.
 - Use email etiquette.
 - Add contextual material to our emails.
- Think of your relationship with your reader as being like a bank account. How can you add credit to your relationship with the reader?
- Mirror your reader’s language and align with them in finding a common cause.
- Your reader is making a contract with you. They are either committed or uncommitted to reading.
- The style of your writing should respond to that level of commitment. For a committed reader, your style can be more formal. For an uncommitted reader, make your style less formal and more ‘spoken’.
- Imagine speaking to your reader, and write down *exactly* what you would say to them.

- Edit your work on three levels: paragraphs, sentences, words.
- Edit paragraphs by using topic sentences.
- Edit sentences by:
 - cutting up long sentences into shorter, separate sentences;
 - simplifying complicated sentences;
 - finding strong subjects and verbs.
- Edit words by:
 - preferring short words to long words;
 - preferring active verbs to passive verbs;
 - removing abstract nouns;
 - cutting unnecessary words.
- Adopt a strategy for editing:
 - Print it out.
 - Take a break.
 - Read it out loud.
 - Pretend you are the intended audience.
 - Use the readability statistics.
 - Be ruthless.

09

Networking: The new conversation

Networking is on the rise. A survey by Common Purpose in 2008 found that 68 per cent of business leaders expected their networking activity to increase over the next five years. Among younger business leaders, the number rose to 75 per cent.

First things first. Networking is *not*:

- selling;
- using other people for your own gain;
- putting people on the spot.

Effective networkers understand that we all need other people to fulfil our ambitions and dreams. Networking is a tool to help us find those people.

Networking can be strategic or spontaneous. At its best, strategic networking prepares us for the spontaneous moments of discovery.

To network or not to network?

Networking is a new name for an old idea. According to the *Oxford English Dictionary*, the word ‘network’ – meaning an interconnected group of people – first appeared in 1946. The words

‘networker’ and ‘networking’, referring to the activities of such groups, do not appear in print until 1976.

Networking has, from the start, been associated with the rise of the businesswoman. In 1980, Mary-Scott Welch published *Networking: The great new way for women to get ahead*. According to her obituary in the *New York Times*, the book was written ‘in an era when more women were competing for jobs traditionally dominated by men’. *Networking* also included the first recorded use of the word ‘network’ as a verb: ‘this book,’ wrote Ms Welch, ‘will show you how to network’.

Networking thus offers a way of doing business that’s less aggressively masculine. Networking emphasizes cooperation and collaboration, rather than individualism and competitiveness. It opens the opportunity for business conversations that more effectively balance ‘pushing’ and ‘pulling’. More like real conversations, in fact. We could say that networking helps to make business more human.

What makes networking effective?

Effective networking relies on three key qualities:

- an ‘abundance mentality’;
- generosity;
- reciprocity.

Cultivating an ‘abundance mentality’

People with a ‘scarcity mentality’ have difficulty sharing. They feel that success depends on holding on to their resources: property, knowledge, relationships. For them, victory means someone else’s defeat, and everyone is out for themselves.

People with an ‘abundance mentality’, in contrast, understand that human resources – knowledge, intelligence, imagination – produce more when they are shared. For them, victory only occurs when we all win; everyone has something unique to offer. An abundance

mentality suggests that there are always three ways to do anything: your way, my way – and a better way.

Being generous

With an abundance mentality, we can give attention to others; and, as we've seen in Chapter 4, attention is at the heart of effective listening. We can also give information more easily and less egotistically.

Fostering reciprocity

None of us can survive without the help of others. Humans seem to be 'hard-wired' for reciprocity; if I give you something, you'll almost certainly feel obliged to offer me something in return. (Reciprocity is one of Robert Cialdini's patterns of influence, which we explored in Chapter 5.) Collaboration requires trust; and reciprocity provides the currency of trust.

Preparing to network

As with any other communication skill, strategic networking benefits from careful preparation. Having a plan will help you to network more effectively and monitor your success afterwards.

Preparing yourself

Networking puts us on the spot. However politely they skirt around the subject, the people we meet at networking events want to know who you are – and quickly. They want not just a name, but an identity: something they can relate to. It helps, therefore, to have a clear 'script' that introduces you to others easily and comfortably.

Build your brand

Our brand is what others know us to be. It's not our personality, or our mission in life. It's closer to *ethos*, but more immediate. Our brand sends the message we want others to know about us.

Think of your brand as sitting 'on the surface'. Other qualities sit below the surface: your beliefs, values, attitudes. Your brand *suggests* those values.

Exercise

Spend a little time working out a few of your core values:

- What matters to you?
- If you didn't have to work, what would you do?
- What puts you 'in the zone'?
- What big problems would you like to do something about?
- What would you like people to say about you at your 75th birthday party?
- Who are your heroes?
- What makes you proud about yourself?
- What makes you different from everyone else?

We demonstrate our values in our achievements. Our achievements are instant talking points; they provide evidence of experience and expertise that others might be looking for.

It's not always easy to remember everything we have achieved. If you make a list of your accomplishments, they'll be ready in the background for you to use.

Exercise

This exercise has a double benefit. It will help you to prepare to network; and it will help you to update your CV.

Make a note of what you're good at, experienced with, trained in and successful at. Note down also how those skills have helped you in specific projects, sports activities, educational or training courses, or work in the community.

Keep the skills and the activities separate. For each skill, look for further examples of activities. For each activity, ask what other skills it demonstrates.

It's up to you to acknowledge and celebrate your accomplishments. And when you start to talk about what you've achieved, you'll begin to speak with passion about something you care about: always an infectious pleasure in conversation.

Create a self-introduction

We introduce ourselves to others so often that it's worth thinking about how to do it well. A self-introduction that develops rapport and generates interest can be one of our greatest networking assets.

Develop a self-introduction that you feel comfortable with. Practise different forms of words and see which ones trigger interest and intrigue.

Your self-introduction: A checklist

- | | |
|----------------------|---|
| Keep it short | Find the headline that summarizes what you do in a single sentence. |
| Use a verb | State what you do – not what you are. Your introduction will be more dynamic and less ambiguous. 'I specialize in minor injuries at an A&E unit' is much more interesting than 'I'm a nurse'. |

Be distinctive	What marks you out from others? What is different about what you do? What's the thing you really like doing?
Provide hooks	Use familiar language, not jargon or technical terms. Above all, keep using verbs: those 'doing' words will bring you alive in the other person's mind.
Engage	Beware the temptation to apologize for your existence! Smile; use clear and steady eye contact; avoid words like 'just' and 'only' ('I'm just a secretary'; 'I'm only here because my manager asked me to come').

Many of us find it uncomfortable to 'blow our own trumpet'. But we don't need to play loudly or boisterously! People need to know what you have to offer, so that they can call on your talents. You know what you have to offer, and how good it is. You need to make it *visible*.

Marshal your resources

As with any other kind of communication, we have resources in three major areas that can help us. They are the rapport-building resources that we explored back in Chapter 1. *Visual* resources include how we look and behave; our vocal resources are our *voice* and the parts of our body that support voice production; and *verbal* resources are the words we use.

Visual resources

Looks matter. Looking good shows that you respect the people you are meeting.

- *Think about your wardrobe.* Build a clothes collection that represents your own values elegantly and simply. Buy a few,

good-quality outfits that you can mix and match. Darker colours generally work better than lighter shades: they hide stains and flatter the figure more effectively; and they tend to give an air of authority. If in doubt, dress *up* for the occasion – it's easier to adjust on the spot than if we are underdressed.

- *Use accessories wisely.* Learn how the extras can pull your image together. Jewellery, ties, scarves, bags, cases – they may project your brand more powerfully than your clothes. Coordination is key.
- *Pay attention to grooming.* The state of your shoes, nails and hair matter. You are meeting people close up. It's worth thinking even about your breath.
- *Mind your manners.* How you stand, move and make eye contact all say something about you. Pay attention to posture. The best thing you can wear is a smile.

Vocal resources

The quality of your voice also matters. Volume, pace and pitch are the three core elements of our voice; we instinctively read a great deal about a person from our perceptions of these three vocal dimensions.

- *Make yourself heard.* You'll probably be speaking against a babble of other voices. Direct your voice clearly at the other person; if they look as if they're straining to hear you, help by raising the volume a little.
- *Slow down.* Articulate clearly and don't gabble. Rushing your words suggests nervousness or lack of interest. Take particular care to pause between sentences.
- *Lower your tone.* A thin, high-pitched voice will suggest a lack of authority or confidence. Use the 7/11 breathing exercise explained in Chapter 7.
- *Use your own accent.* Be proud of your voice: it's a vital component of your identity. If your accent is distinct or strong,

people may have to work a little harder to adjust to your voice, so...

- *Speak clearly.* Make sure all the consonants are clear when you speak (all the letters that are not A, E, I, O or U). Use your lips and tongue well.

Top tip

Three vocal mannerisms have appeared recently, which you should try to avoid.

- **Uptalk:** the habit of ending every sentence on an upward inflection, like it's, you know, like, a question?
- **Run-on sentences:** the tendency to run every sentence into the next sentence so that the listener finds it hard to decide whether you're making a point or just gabbling on and on...
- **Vocal fry:** that guttural growl at the back of the throat, otherwise known as 'creaky voice' or 'quacking'. Typical vocal fryers include Britney Spears and Kim Kardashian, although the habit is not confined to women.

There's some evidence that all three habits are spreading, especially among young people. And there's also evidence that all three may be bad news for their career prospects. If in doubt, record yourself in conversation or ask a friend whether they hear you using these habits.

Verbal resources

Among your verbal resources are your self-introduction and the rapport-building remarks and questions. Listen, also, for the words the other person uses and adjust your vocabulary to theirs. Echoing the actual words a person uses can help to build rapport very quickly, if done subtly.

Do you have a card?

Your business card is the trace you leave behind you. It represents you in someone's memory after you've finished talking. If they want to meet you again, they use your card to do so.

- *The card should reflect your 'brand'.* Does the design say what you want it to say? Do the colours and typefaces suggest your values and style? Are they compatible with your website or blog, if you have one?
- *Essential information should be easy to see.* Your name, your company and the contact details should leap off the card.
- *Make use of space.* Don't clutter the card with unnecessary pictures or design features.
- *Quality pays.* Choose durable, good-quality card. It's almost certainly worth having your card printed professionally, if you can afford it.

If you're new to the job market, or between jobs, take the trouble to create a new card containing your contact details. Handing out a card with outdated information is not a good idea – and makes an even worse impression if the information is hastily crossed out or overwritten. You may feel uncomfortable offering a stranger your address; a telephone number and email address is quite sufficient.

Look after your inner self

Networking is exhausting. Most of us meet a few new people every day, but few of us find it natural meeting dozens of new people in a couple of hours. Every new meeting is an opportunity, but it is also a challenge.

Building up your confidence

Take care not to rehearse failure. (Remember the notes on rehearsing in Chapter 7.) Instead of playing out all the scenarios that could go wrong, rehearse yourself succeeding at the networking event.

Rehearsing success is not ‘positive thinking’; it’s running successful conversations in our heads, in a carefully disciplined way.

Exercise

Here’s how to rehearse success:

- 1 Make yourself comfortable, in a quiet room, and close your eyes. Remove all distractions.
- 2 Imagine a television set. Set it down across the room and switch it on.
- 3 On the television screen, run a video of yourself performing well at a networking meeting. Watch the video carefully and notice what ‘you’ are doing. Now adjust the video to make it really compelling. Turn up the sound; increase the screen size. Now, step into the movie so that you are seeing the action through your own eyes, as if you were already there. Become aware of what you are *doing*, how you *look*, how you *sound* and how you *feel*.
- 4 Now step out again and shift your viewpoint a little way into the future beyond the event. Now you are looking back on it, taking notes and thinking about what you did well. Notice how you feel about it now.
- 5 Come back to now. Freeze-frame the video at a point where you can easily remember the image. That image will be your access point into the video, so that you can rerun it whenever you want.

Identifying goals

Now that you've prepared yourself, you need to set yourself clear goals for the networking event.

Think of your networking goals in terms both of what you want, and what you want to give. How will you know that you've got what you want? Or that you've given what you intend to give?

Sometimes we are set goals or targets by our managers. If so, make sure you're happy with what you're being asked to achieve; negotiate if necessary, so that you feel in control of your goals.

The skills of networking conversations

However much you prepare, the moment comes when you have to walk into the room and start talking to someone.

There's no one way of doing this. Some people can't resist starting with a humorous remark; others use well-established lines like: 'Have we met before?' or 'What brings you here?' The important thing is to do it. Make contact.

Establishing rapport

Look back at the exercise on building rapport in Chapter 1. That five-step strategy is guaranteed to help you network. Start positive or neutral. Avoid emotive subjects such as religion and politics – at least to start with – and be very careful about assumptions linking one person with another. 'Are you two married?' can be an embarrassing opener – as I found to my cost a few nights before writing this chapter.

It's likely that you won't remember the person's name within the first few minutes of your conversation. Too much else will be going on. A few simple tricks will help a name to stick.

- *Use their name* on first introductions:
 - *Hi, I'm Megan.*
 - *Megan, hi... Pleased to meet you. I'm Tony.*
- *Ask for the name again if necessary.* Taking the trouble to ask is another gift that will be appreciated.
- *Use the other person's name once or twice during the conversation.* Some people do this better than others. It might feel a little awkward or false, but it will help you to remember the name.

Keeping the conversation going

In the early stages of a conversation, try to listen more than speaking. Be the first to ask a question; then listen to the answer. Make sure that it is an open question, beginning with one of the six 'w's:

- *What do you do for a living?*
- *Where do you meet most of your clients?*
- *When did you start on this line of business?*
- *Who is your link with the host organization?*
- *How did you start out?*
- *Why did you take this path?*

Now share something about yourself. (Remember the rule in that exercise in Chapter 1: no more than three questions before you make a different kind of move.) Try to link your remark to what the other person has said. Summarize and paraphrase. Check your understanding of what the other person is saying; this keeps you focused, gives you time to think of something else to say and shows that you're listening.

Another way to keep the conversation going is to bring someone else in:

Chris, come and join us. We're just talking about...

I know who you should meet. Let me try to find Firoze...

‘Passing the ball’ in this way can relax or enhance a conversation. It can also be a good way to bring a conversation to a close politely: having introduced people to each other, you can excuse yourself and move on.

Joining groups

Approaching a group of people differs slightly from approaching an individual. Being able to ‘read’ the group is helpful.

- *Arrive early.* One of the best ways to manage groups is to be in at the start of one.
- *Use previous contacts.* Everyone you speak to early in the event is a potential ‘joiner’ later: use one as a link person if you want to join a group.
- *Judge the tightness of the group.* How closely are people standing to each other? How is their eye contact? Can you see an opening, or is the group broadcasting its exclusivity by turning all backs on the rest of the room?
- *Exploit fractures.* Conversations rarely survive being extended beyond three people. Groups of four or more will probably be audiences, listening to a single, dominant person. You could join the audience; or you could look for two people talking and gently insinuate yourself as a third.
- *Pick off stragglers.* Not everyone in the group will be entirely ‘in the circle’. Find someone at the edge – perhaps they’re looking as if they want an excuse to move on – and approach them.
- *Use listening time to establish your presence.* Make eye contact; respond to what someone says with smiles and nods. Ask them a question.
- *Ask permission.* Find different ways of asking permission to enter new space:
 - *Excuse me, I don’t mean to interrupt, but I overheard you talking about...*

- *Forgive me for interrupting, but am I right in thinking that...?*
- *Sorry to barge in, but can I just ask you about what you were saying?*

‘Playing host’ is a brilliant way to break into groups. Pick up a bottle of wine or a plate of nibbles, and circulate. You’re putting people at their ease; you’re offering gifts (always a great way to get people interested in you); you’re able to introduce people to each other. Playing host also helps *you*: it gives you a certain authority (or at least something to do), and it gives you control. You can judge when to stay with someone and when to move on.

Closing the conversation

Whether the conversation has gone well, or not gone anywhere in particular, take care to close it well. The final impression we make is almost as important as the first one.

Never leave someone abruptly. To exit a conversation simply, find a way to connect the person to someone else. Make the introduction; make sure that it has stuck (are they actually exchanging more than one remark with each other?); and walk away. Alternatively, use a plausible reason for leaving. Maybe you are expecting a colleague to arrive; maybe there is someone you need to speak to before they leave.

The parting stage of a conversation should always involve action of some sort. Lots of actions could end a conversation. You could:

- invite the person to meet someone else;
- make a gift of information (or food, or drink...);
- agree to meet again;
- exchange cards.

Exchanging cards

The etiquette of exchanging business cards has become more sophisticated in recent years. Business cards are gifts; treat them as such and you won't go far wrong.

- *Keep your cards in good condition.* This applies to cards you receive as well as your own. Business cardholders are a good idea; one for your own, one for cards offered.
- *Give your card respectfully.* Choose who you offer your card to. Give your card when it's asked for; asking for a card is a compliment, so treat it as such. Ask permission to offer your card. If you give your card with respect, you'll instil respect for yourself. Above all, don't leave a pile of cards on a table.
- *Receive cards with respect.* The person offering is also paying a compliment, by trusting you with their contact details. Treat the card as a gift. Take it carefully; look at it; read it (aloud, perhaps); offer a compliment or a positive comment ('What an interesting design'; 'Ah, I see you're based in London'). Put the card away respectfully, perhaps only after you have parted.

It's a good idea to make notes on business cards: where you met, who introduced you, interesting information, agreed follow-up actions. However, you should never write on a business card in the other person's presence. (Unless they give you permission to do so, of course.)

Following up and building your network

Don't waste the opportunities you've worked so hard for. Once you've made contact with people, think about how you can make use of that contact. Review your cards and notes at the end of the event. Record in your diary any obvious or immediate plans for follow-up.

Find a way of organizing your network contacts. If you can align your system to other systems you use for personal details – your personal organizer, your email archives – so much the better.

Reconnecting with people

Having the contacts is of little use if you don't use them. There are lots of ways of reconnecting to people you've met. You could follow up fast, send a gift – information, links to resources or other people – or invite them to make contact. Don't annoy or exhaust your new contacts, but gentle 'nudges' over time might work. A good way to maintain contact is to ask for help.

The Netbank

We have a 'net account' with everyone in our network. Just like a real bank account, our net accounts with people can be in credit or overdrawn. (Whenever we say 'I'm in your debt', or 'I'm obliged', we're signalling the need to balance our net account with someone.)

Diane Darling suggests that the best way to check our net balance with someone is to try to make a withdrawal.

- When you need to call them, will you feel comfortable doing so?
- How long has it been since you put something into the account?
- The last time they asked you to help, did you do so?

If you think your net account with someone is dangerously low, make a deposit.

- Find something you can do for the person.
- Don't ask them for anything.
- Identify people with whom you are in 'net credit'. Could they help you with a 'net loan'?

Deposits in your Netbank gather ‘net interest’. A small deposit can quickly garner bigger returns.

Exploring

Effective networkers go sideways! They use every opportunity to practise their networking skills and actively look for new business relationships.

Find new ways of making your voice heard. The technologies of networking are growing fast: social networking sites, email, instant messaging, blogging... Explore how you can use electronic media to promote your messages and offer useful gifts to people in your network.

The 10 commandments of effective networking

- 1 You get what you give.
- 2 Be yourself.
- 3 Honour your relationships.
- 4 Share; don't hoard.
- 5 Ask for what you want.
- 6 Promote yourself professionally.
- 7 Move on when necessary.
- 8 Record all your contacts.
- 9 Follow up.
- 10 Expand your horizons.

Summary points

- Networking is the art of building and sustaining mutually beneficial relationships.
- Networking is *not*:
 - selling;
 - using other people for your own gain;
 - putting people on the spot.
- What makes networking effective:
 - an abundance mentality;
 - generosity;
 - reciprocity.
- Prepare to network by:
 - preparing yourself;
 - building your brand;
 - finding your core values;
 - listing your achievements and accomplishments;
 - creating a self-introduction;
 - marshalling your resources: visual, vocal, verbal.
- Your business card should:
 - reflect your brand;
 - be easy to read;
 - be of high quality.
- Look after your inner self:
 - build up your confidence;
 - rehearse success;
 - identify your goals.

- In the networking conversation:
 - establish rapport;
 - use techniques to keep the conversation going;
 - practise joining groups;
 - close the conversation respectfully;
 - use good etiquette for exchanging cards.
- To follow up and build your network:
 - record your contacts;
 - reconnect with people;
 - ask for help;
 - create a network map;
 - keep the connections alive;
 - volunteer;
 - use your organization's facilities;
 - start your own network;
 - explore;
 - find new ways of making your voice heard.
- The 10 commandments of effective networking:
 - You get what you give.
 - Be yourself.
 - Honour your relationships.
 - Share; don't hoard.
 - Ask for what you want.
 - Promote yourself professionally.
 - Move on when necessary.
 - Record all your contacts.
 - Follow up.
 - Expand your horizons.

APPENDIX

Where to go from here

Communication is continuous, and we never finish learning how to improve. My blog explores issues and events relating to the material in this book. You can find it at: bit.ly/1zgJBvo.

Here are some thoughts about books and other resources that will take further the ideas we've explored in this book.

About this book

You can find a copy of the Economist Intelligence Unit's report, *Communication Barriers in the Modern Workplace*, here: <https://bit.ly/2OTJ2Vn>.

Find a link to the Interact consultancy's report here: <https://bit.ly/2DhDrmF>.

The GMAC's 2017 Corporate Recruiters Survey is available here: <https://bit.ly/2Pwo5Au>.

Chapter 1: What is communication?

The fullest explanation I have found of the transmission model of communication is on Mick Underwood's magnificent (and award-winning) website: bit.ly/29CaP7Q.

I draw on the work of Joe Griffin and Ivan Tyrrell throughout this book. You can find out about their work by going to the Human

Givens Institute website (hgi.org.uk). Their book, *Human Givens: The new approach to emotional health and clear thinking*, is an excellent introduction to this body of knowledge and research.

Chris Dyas explains his five steps to building rapport here: bit.ly/29xhu5U.

The Wikipedia article on Paul Watzlawick provides useful information and links.

Chapter 2: What's your communication style?

My model of communication styles draws on a number of sources.

I've borrowed the term 'functional' from the styles model illustrated in the 2017 report by the Economist Intelligence Unit. This model seems to be based on the work of Mark Murphy, founder of Intelligence IQ – although the report does not, I think, acknowledge him. Murphy's model is broadly similar to the Wilson Social Styles model and the Insights Discovery method, both of which I have used in my own consultancy work. You can find information on all three approaches online. Insights claims that the Discovery product, like the Myers-Briggs profile, is a personality assessment tool, drawing on the work of Carl Gustav Jung. My own model doesn't claim to demonstrate anything about personality.

The 'push' and 'pull' influencing styles are part of situational influencing theory, often associated with the work of David Berlew and Roger Harrison.

Empathizing and systemizing are concepts used by Simon Baron-Cohen. Check out his book, *The Essential Difference*, for more information (Penguin, London, 2003).

Chapter 3: Seven ways to improve your conversations

First- and second-stage thinking are notions that inform Edward de Bono's work. Look at *Lateral Thinking in Management* (Penguin, London, 1982). The four types of conversation derive from the work of Michael Wallacek, who may have been influenced by Werner Erhard.

Chris Argyris's ladder of inference is best found in *The Fifth Discipline Fieldbook*, edited by Peter Senge and others (Nicholas Brealey, London, 1994).

For more on mind maps, see Tony Buzan's *Use your Head* (BBC, London, 1974).

Chapter 4: The skills of enquiry

Nancy Kline's *Time to Think* (Ward Lock, London, 1999) is a fascinating study of deep listening.

Chapter 5: The skills of persuasion

Aristotle explains his three modes of appeal in *The Art of Rhetoric* (Penguin Classics, London, 1991).

Caroline Goyder includes her ideas on voice production in her book *Gravitas* (Vermilion, London, 2014).

Peter Thompson's *Persuading Aristotle* (Kogan Page, London, 1999) entertainingly relates classical rhetoric to modern business techniques.

For more on pyramids, look at Barbara Minto's *The Pyramid Principle* (Pitman, London, 1987).

Chapter 6: Tough conversations

Find out how well Paul McLean's model of the triune brain is surviving:

bit.ly/1PaQK8G.

bit.ly/1PB8vID.

Find out more about the limbic system here: bit.ly/29HkLz9.

Explore our needs as human beings here: bit.ly/29xg4mm.

And you can take an online emotional needs audit here: bit.ly/29xg1at.

Chapter 7: Making a presentation

You can find a worked example of Monroe's motivated sequence here: bit.ly/1ndUE4m.

PRAISE is based loosely on the material in *Made to Stick* by Chip and Dan Heath (Arrow, London, 2008).

Jens Kjeldsen has analysed slide usage in his paper, 'The Rhetoric of PowerPoint': bit.ly/209vX7d.

Max Atkinson's book *Lend Me Your Ears* (Vermilion, London, 2004) takes a strikingly new approach to the subject of presenting and speech writing.

Chapter 8: Putting it in writing

Justin Kruger's paper on email's potential for misunderstandings is here: bit.ly/SyB0jo.

Kristin Byron's article, 'Carrying too heavy a load?', is available here: bit.ly/1OrR5QJ.

Jay Heinrichs talks about the tenses of persuasion in his book *Thank You for Arguing* (Three Rivers Press, New York, 2013).

Alan Barker's *Writing at Work* (Industrial Society, London, 1999) is a comprehensive guide to writing business documents.

Chapter 9: Networking

Two books taking usefully complementary approaches to networking are Steven D'Souza's *Brilliant Networking* (Pearson Education, Harlow, 2008), and *Power Networking* by Donna Fisher and Sandy Vilas (Bard Press, Atlanta, GA, 2000).

